

Discrimination in Access to Corporate Insiders: Evidence from a Field Experiment

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ABSTRACT

We examine whether investor characteristics influence access to corporate insiders. Using a pre-registered 2×2×2 field experiment, we send meeting requests from fictitious investors to 2,731 U.S. public companies, systematically manipulating investor race (Black and White), gender (female and male), and type (retail and boutique professional). We find evidence of racial discrimination: White investors receive approvals for meetings 34% more often than Black investors. This discrimination persists across investor types, which we manipulate using custom email domains and websites. In contrast, we do not find evidence of gender-based differences in initial meeting access. Further, investor type does not affect meeting access: retail and boutique professional investors receive meeting invitations at comparable rates, challenging the conventional belief that retail investors cannot readily obtain meetings with corporate insiders. Our findings document that information access varies systematically by investor characteristics, advancing our understanding of the landscape of corporate information access.

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“Investors lose confidence in the fairness of the markets when they know that other participants may exploit ‘unerodable informational advantages’ derived not from hard work or insights, but from their access to company information.”

– United States Securities and Exchange Commission

1. Introduction

Discrimination poses a significant challenge in modern economies. By preventing the optimal allocation of talent and resources, group-based discrimination reduces aggregate economic output (Bell et al., 2019; Hsieh et al., 2019). Prior research documents gender and racial disparities across various economic settings, including labor markets, housing, consumer credit, and, increasingly, financial market contexts.¹ Recent studies have documented disparities in financial market settings such as financial advisory services (Bhattacharya et al., 2024), credit markets (Douglass et al., 2019; Bartlett et al., 2022), analyst participation in earnings calls (Flam et al., 2023), and trade credit interactions (Costello et al., 2024). While this growing body of work provides valuable insights into differential treatment across demographic groups, important questions remain about how disparities manifest in specific information channels within financial markets, the extent to which discrimination contributes to these patterns, and the mechanisms through which discrimination operates.

In this paper, we examine discrimination in an important but understudied information channel: investor access to corporate insiders through private meetings. Private interactions between investors and corporate insiders are a pervasive feature of modern financial markets. Research shows these meetings improve investor trading performance and analyst forecast accuracy (Green et al., 2014; Solomon and Soltes, 2015; Bushee et al., 2017; Bradley et al., 2022).

¹ Documented disparities or discrimination, particularly related to racial or gender characteristics, include those in wage and hiring practices (e.g., Bertrand and Mullainathan, 2004; Lang et al., 2005; Blau and Kahn, 2017; Kline et al., 2022; Evsyukova et al., 2025), housing access (Christensen and Timmins, 2022), and consumer pricing (Ayres and Siegelman, 1995).

Becht et al. (2026) further show that meetings convey predominantly soft information, the type most difficult to obtain through alternative channels. These findings suggest that differential access to such meetings has meaningful and hard-to-replicate informational consequences. It is therefore notable that corporate investor relations (IR) departments serve as the gatekeepers to these interactions, creating an environment where discriminatory practices may arise. Importantly, IR professionals are not merely gatekeepers for senior management; recent survey evidence indicates that investors rate calls or meetings with IR among their most valued information sources for investment research (Brunswick Group, 2026).

Several institutional features distinguish the IR setting from other contexts where competitive forces typically discipline discrimination. First, information asymmetry prevents any investor from observing how IR professionals treat other investors, thereby reducing the reputational costs that might discipline discriminatory behavior. Unlike labor markets with Equal Employment Opportunity (EEO) compliance or consumer markets with pricing disclosures (e.g., mortgage loans), no reporting requirements exist for IR access. Second, firms likely struggle to quantify the opportunity costs of discrimination because the value of foregone investor relationships remains unobservable. Firms cannot observe the counterfactual (how engagement with excluded investors might have generated additional investment) leaving the true opportunity costs of discrimination hidden. Thus, biased decision-making can persist, not because it is costless, but because there is little visibility into foregone benefits.

To test our research questions, we conduct a pre-registered field experiment using correspondence testing methodology.² Field experiments provide an effective approach for

² Our study received IRB approval from our respective universities and was pre-registered on the American Economic Association's registry for randomized controlled trials (<https://www.socialscienceregistry.org>). Note to reviewer(s): We have attached the pre-registration document as supplemental material with this submission.

studying discrimination in investor-IR communications because these interactions typically occur privately, creating a setting where observational data on investor access are generally unavailable. Further, field experiments avoid the omitted variables problem inherent in observational studies examining discrimination (Guryan and Charles, 2013). As is common in field experiments that examine discrimination, our design relies on deception as we contact IR professionals using fictitious investor identities. We discuss the ethical considerations of this approach and the steps we take to mitigate potential harms in Section 3.5. We implement a $2 \times 2 \times 2$ between-subjects design, systematically manipulating three investor characteristics in meeting requests sent to IR departments of 2,731 U.S. public companies: race (Black or White), gender (female or male), and investor type (retail or boutique professional).³ We employ stratified randomization, balancing firms across experimental conditions on market capitalization, IR email personalization, and retail ownership percentage.

The inclusion of investor type as a manipulated characteristic is important for two reasons. First, any differential treatment of retail versus professional investors by IR departments is independently important for understanding the landscape of information access, with direct implications for investor protection and market fairness. Second, investor type allows us to examine patterns in the data that provide some evidence on the mechanism underlying any observed discrimination. Economic theory suggests two primary drivers of discrimination. First, taste-based discrimination occurs when decision-makers exhibit an intrinsic preference against a specific group and willingly incur economic costs to avoid interaction (Becker, 1957). Second,

³ Our professional investor condition represents boutique (small, unrecognized) investment firms rather than established institutional investors such as Vanguard or BlackRock. This design choice allows us to test whether the signal of professional affiliation per se, absent the reputational capital of a well-known institution, affects IR access. It also reflects the empirical reality that over 16,000 small and mid-sized boutique investment advisers operate in the U.S. market (ICI, 2025).

statistical discrimination occurs when decision-makers use observable characteristics (like race or gender) as a proxy for unobservable economic traits, such as capital or sophistication (Phelps, 1972; Arrow, 1973). If IR professionals engage in statistical discrimination (using race as a proxy for unobserved traits such as access to capital or sophistication) providing a clear signal of investor professionalism should attenuate the disparity. Alternatively, if disparities stem from taste-based discrimination, investor type should not meaningfully moderate responses because the underlying preference remains fixed across professional and retail profiles.

Overall, we receive 433 meeting approvals, corresponding to a 16.3% approval rate. Our results reveal discrimination in corporate IR departments' responses based on investor race. White investors are 34% more likely to be granted meetings than Black investors. In contrast to these race-based findings, we observe no evidence that investor gender or type influences initial meeting access. The absence of a gender effect is notable given that prior research documents gender disparities in related financial market contexts, with evidence of discrimination operating against both women (Bhattacharya et al., 2024) and men (Gornall and Strebulaev, 2025) depending on the setting. The absence of an investor type effect challenges the conventional belief that retail investors cannot readily obtain meetings with corporate insiders. Importantly, our pre-registered power analyses indicate that our design provides sufficient statistical power to detect even small main effects in our models, suggesting these null results are not artifacts of sample size.⁴

We additionally examine three pre-registered secondary outcomes. First, we examine the full spectrum of IR engagement through a responsiveness measure that captures whether firms ignore requests (81% of emails sent), respond but decline engagement (2%), offer email-only

⁴ We conducted simulation-based power analyses following Floyd and List (2016), using parameters from Heinrichs (2014) (a 44% email response rate and 73% meeting rate). Assuming a baseline 32% meeting probability, our simulations indicate 80% power to detect small effects for main effects (e.g., odds ratios of roughly 0.77) and small-to-medium effects for interactions (e.g., odds ratios of roughly 0.55) (see the pre-registration for further detail).

communication (1%), or agree to a meeting (16%). We find that the racial disparity in meeting access persists across this broader measure, with Black investors receiving lower levels of responsiveness, although this is largely driven by meeting outcomes given the scarcity of responses that declined a meeting or offered email-only access. Second, we investigate the “quality” of access by examining whether investors receive offers to meet with C-suite executives. While we receive relatively few offers to meet with C-suite executives, we find evidence that conditional on securing a meeting, female investors are less likely than male investors to be offered a meeting. Third, we examine the speed of IR responses to investor meeting requests. We find some evidence that Black investors receive faster responses than White investors; however, additional tests reveal this stems from some White investors receiving outlier email responses weeks after the initial request.

Our main results, which document that the racial gap in meeting approval rates persists at similar magnitudes for both retail and professional investors, are more consistent with taste-based discrimination than with traditional models of statistical discrimination. However, as with most field designs, we cannot fully disentangle these mechanisms. First, although we designed the professional investor condition to signal sophistication and access to capital, the strength of this signal may have varied across recipients. IR professionals who conducted background checks would have discovered that our fictitious investments firms are not SEC-registered, potentially reducing its credibility. Importantly, professional investors received meeting approvals at rates comparable to retail investors, and the racial disparity persisted within this group, suggesting the signal was not uniformly dismissed.⁵ Second, it remains possible that demographic-level statistical beliefs extend to affiliated organizations. For instance, if IR professionals apply beliefs about

⁵ For example, one IR professional proposed meeting our investor at upcoming institutional investor conferences: “Coincidentally, [redacted] will be in NYC for a couple of conferences this week – Raymond James TMT and Consumer Conference on Wednesday, Jefferies Specialty Finance Conference on Thursday, and then the KeyBanc Consumer Conference (virtually) on Friday. Any chance that you or your team will be at any of these conferences?”

group-level wealth or capital access to firms associated with certain individuals, even when stated firm characteristics (e.g., assets under management) are held constant, the professional signal may not attenuate disparities. For these reasons, we interpret our findings as relatively more consistent with taste-based discrimination while acknowledging that our design cannot completely rule out certain forms of statistical discrimination operating at the individual or organizational level.

This paper makes several key contributions. First, we provide novel causal evidence on the role of non-economic characteristics in gating access to corporate insiders. Thus, we extend the recent literature exploring disparities in professional analyst settings (Bloomfield et al., 2021; Flam et al., 2023), and discrimination in contexts such as financial advice (Bhattacharya et al., 2024), and other financial interactions (Dougal et al., 2019; Costello et al., 2024; Feng et al., 2024). Our study builds on this research by providing causal evidence of bias affecting access to a key information channel (corporate insiders) that yields significant investor benefits (Bushee et al., 2017; Bradley et al., 2022). We identify race as a specific friction impacting information access that systematically disadvantages Black investors. In doing so, our findings shed light on practices that are otherwise hidden from regulators, policymakers, and market participants, potentially informing future investor protection regulations, IR disclosure requirements, or corporate governance standards.

Second, our results contribute to understanding when and how gender discrimination operates in financial markets. Our finding of no gender-based barriers to initial access contrasts with Gornall and Strebulaev (2025), who document that venture capitalists show greater interest in pitches by female entrepreneurs. Yet, our C-suite access results seemingly align with Bhattacharya et al. (2024), who find that female investors receive lower-quality financial advice than male investors. Together, these findings suggest that discrimination in financial markets is

highly context-dependent, varying not only across settings but also across different stages of interaction within the same setting.

Third, we contribute to the literature on information asymmetry between investors in financial markets (e.g., Glosten and Milgrom, 1985; Lambert et al., 2012), with implications for corporate governance, market efficiency, and investor protection. Our findings suggest that access to private information channels varies systematically across racial groups, creating differential information environments that can impair effective monitoring by investors (e.g., Armstrong et al., 2010). Furthermore, by disadvantaging a group of potential investors, such discrimination may reduce the diversity of information and perspectives being impounded into stock prices, with potential consequences for price efficiency and capital allocation.

Finally, we contribute to the debate on taste-based versus statistical discrimination in financial markets. Our results contrast with concurrent work by Brown et al. (2024) who study sustainability inquiries to U.K. firms by male retail investors. Brown et al. (2024) show attenuated discrimination toward male ethnic minority investors when those investors signal personal wealth, interpreting this as evidence of statistical discrimination. In the U.S. market, we find that providing a professional signal does not attenuate racial discrimination for both male and female investors. These diverging inferences suggest that discrimination in financial markets is situational. In our setting, the persistence of bias despite signals of professional sophistication suggests that frictions in access to corporate insiders are more consistent with taste-based preferences.

2. Experimental Setting

We posit that requests for meetings with corporate IR departments provide an ideal setting to examine discrimination in investor access. This rests on two premises: (1) IR interactions represent a meaningful channel for accessing insiders and information, and (2) IR departments

exist within circumstances that are potentially conducive to discriminatory behaviors, lacking the disciplining market forces that commonly exist in other settings (e.g., Becker, 1957; Kline et al., 2022).

2.1 Investor Access, Information Asymmetry, and the IR Role

Several studies demonstrate that investor access to corporate insiders yields valuable informational advantages that translate into trading gains (Solomon and Soltes, 2015; Bushee et al., 2017; Bushee et al., 2018; Cheng et al., 2019; Bradley et al., 2022). Sell-side analysts similarly benefit from management access (Green et al., 2014; Soltes, 2014; Choy and Hope, 2024). These private meetings with corporate managers provide capital market participants with an additional informational channel, potentially conveying both ‘hard’ and ‘soft’ information about firm prospects. Underscoring the importance of soft information, Mayew and Venkatachalam (2012) show that vocal cues and managerial affective states during earnings calls can be informative about firms’ future financial performance. Thus, by securing meetings with corporate insiders, investors gain access to a unique information channel that has been empirically linked to informational trading advantages.

IR departments act as gatekeepers to securing meetings with corporate insiders, of which IR professionals are one. Research shows that facilitating communication between investors, especially professional investors, and managers is a critical IR function (Bushee and Miller, 2012). In survey work, IR Officers (IROs) rate private calls as highly important for conveying their company’s message, higher than public filings or analyst reports, saying that IROs’ job performance often depends on securing investor meetings (Brown et al., 2019). Experimental work suggests IROs grant preferential access and information to favored professional investors (Asay et al., 2024). Other survey data confirm that responding to shareholder requests and arranging

meetings are primary IR responsibilities (Laskin, 2009), and email requests represent a viable channel to source meetings, yielding substantial response and meeting rates (Heinrichs, 2014). Collectively, the literature establishes that arranging meetings via email is a core IR function and is a key channel for investors seeking management access.

Importantly, interactions with IR professionals are themselves a valued information channel, not merely a conduit to C-suite access. In a recent survey of 100 institutional U.S. buy-side investors, the Brunswick Group (2026) reports that 63% of respondents rated ‘Calls or meetings with IR’ as ‘extremely’ or ‘very important’ for conducting investment research, ranking third among eleven information sources and trailing only meetings with the C-suite (77%) and investor conference presentations (65%). This evidence indicates that the type of interaction our experiment measures, a call or meeting with an IR professional, constitutes a substantive informational resource for investors in its own right.

Although IR departments have historically focused on institutional investors, the landscape of retail investor engagement is shifting. Retail investors now represent a growing and strategically important stakeholder for public companies. A recent S&P Global Market Intelligence report (2022) characterizes retail investor relations outreach as evolving ‘from a check-the-box activity to a strategic imperative for public companies,’ driven by the democratization of market participation, digital platforms, and generational shifts in investor behavior. According to FINRA, more than 58 million U.S. households held equities as of 2023, and retail trading accounts for roughly 25% of daily market volume (Goldman Sachs Research, cited in S&P Global Market Intelligence, 2025). Companies such as BASF have responded by employing dedicated IR staff to support retail shareholders via ‘hotlines, email, and regular presentations.’ Accordingly, it is increasingly common for retail investors to initiate direct contact with IR departments, and for IR

departments to view such engagement as part of their core responsibilities (S&P Global Market Intelligence, 2025). Our experimental design reflects this emerging institutional reality.

2.2 Discrimination in Financial Markets: Theory and Prior Evidence

Economic theory offers two primary frameworks for understanding discrimination. The first, taste-based discrimination, posits that decision-makers exhibit an intrinsic prejudice or animus against members of a particular group (Becker, 1957). In this model, discrimination is a preference, and an agent who acts on it is willing to incur a cost, such as forgoing a profitable transaction, to avoid interacting with members of a disfavored group. Economic theory suggests that competitive market forces should, over time, discipline taste-based discrimination, as non-discriminating firms will outperform their prejudiced competitors. The second framework, statistical discrimination, proposes that discrimination is a belief-based phenomenon rooted in information asymmetry (Phelps, 1972; Arrow, 1973). Here, decision-makers use observable group characteristics, such as race or gender, as a proxy for unobservable but economically relevant traits, such as an investor's access to capital or sophistication. While statistical discrimination should dissipate under perfect information, it can persist when acquiring individual information is costly or when available signals are noisy.

Distinguishing between these two mechanisms is a central challenge in the empirical literature studying discrimination, as they can produce similar outcomes with different underlying mechanisms. The key distinction lies in how they respond to new information: providing clear, credible signals about an individual's qualifications should mitigate statistical discrimination but would have little effect on taste-based discrimination.

A growing body of empirical research has documented disparities in various financial market settings. For example, research finds that female analysts face penalties for deviating from

stereotypically male behaviors (Bloomfield et al., 2021) and that ethnic minority analysts participate less frequently in public earnings calls (Flam et al., 2023). Disparities reflect observable differences in treatment or outcomes between groups, and can arise for many reasons beyond bias, such as structural barriers or unequal access to resources. While disparities are important indicators of inequality, they do not establish the presence of discriminatory actions. Discrimination, however, refers to disparities that result specifically from unfair treatment based on group membership itself.

A few studies document discriminatory treatment in other financial settings, such as financial advisors in Hong Kong providing lower-quality advice to women (Bhattacharya et al., 2024), and customers being more likely to delay payments to female or Black trade credit officers (Costello et al., 2024). Perhaps most closely related to our setting, Brown et al. (2024) provide concurrent evidence of ethnic discrimination in investor relations settings, finding that U.K. IR professionals are less responsive to sustainability-related inquiries from male retail investors with ethnic minority-sounding names. Our study contributes complementary evidence regarding financial information from the U.S. market, examining discrimination based both on race and gender in access to financial information through private meeting requests with corporate insiders. Additionally, by including both retail and professional investors in our design, we examine whether discrimination extends beyond retail investors to interactions with seemingly sophisticated market participants who also have access to capital.

Despite this growing evidence, an important and largely opaque channel of information flow remains unexplored: the process of securing private meetings with corporate insiders. Whether discriminatory biases affect access in the highly professionalized setting of U.S. corporate investor relations is an open empirical question. On one hand, the pressures of capital markets and

an increasing corporate focus on diversity, equity, and inclusion might be expected to curb discriminatory behavior. On the other hand, certain institutional features of IR interactions may weaken the market forces that typically discipline discrimination. While Becker (1957)'s model suggests that discriminating firms should face performance penalties for forgoing valuable transactions, several factors may attenuate this discipline in the IR context. First, the value of individual investor relations is often highly uncertain and realized over long time horizons, making it difficult for firms to attribute performance outcomes to specific access decisions. Second, unlike in labor markets where worker productivity can be more directly observed and measured, the benefits of investor relations often depend on intangible factors, future market conditions, and investor behavior that are difficult to quantify *ex ante*. Third, investment decisions are influenced by numerous factors beyond IR access, creating noise in any feedback mechanism that might otherwise discipline discriminatory behavior.

This unique environment creates a tension between how IR professionals might ideally function and how they behave under uncertainty and resource constraints. IR professionals are tasked with allocating their limited time to investors who provide the most value to the firm—a decision based on attributes like capital and sophistication, which are universally valued (de Albuquerque et al., 2025). However, because capital and sophistication are often unobservable at the initial point of contact, IR professionals may instead rely on attributes like race or gender, characteristics for which any value assigned to them is subjective and depends on the decision-makers' own beliefs or preferences. This potential substitution of objective for subjective attributes sets the stage for potential discrimination, whether it be statistical or taste-based. This institutional context therefore provides a setting to investigate whether, and how, discrimination shapes access to an important information channel in modern capital markets.

2.3 Statistical versus Taste-Based Discrimination in the Investor Relations Setting

Disentangling taste-based from statistical discrimination is empirically challenging, yet important for understanding the nature of bias and for designing effective interventions. Our experimental design, which manipulates signals of non-economic (race, gender) and economic (investor type) attributes, allows us to explore patterns in the data consistent with each theory. We discuss each mechanism below, derive testable predictions, and acknowledge key limitations of our approach.

2.3.1 Statistical Discrimination in the Investor Relations Setting

In our context, statistical discrimination would occur if an IR professional uses an investor's race or gender as a proxy for unobservable, economically relevant characteristics. IR professionals operate under time and resource constraints and must prioritize engagement with investors they perceive as most valuable to the firm. Such value could be defined by an investor's access to capital, sophistication, long-term investment horizon, or likelihood of becoming a significant shareholder. For example, an IR professional might engage in statistical discrimination based on race if they believe, based on stereotypes or aggregate statistics, that Black investors possess less capital than White investors. This belief, while a stereotype, could be rooted in societal-level data; for instance, the well-documented racial wealth gap in the United States shows a White-to-Black per capita ratio of approximately 6 to 1 (Derenoncourt et al., 2024). An IR professional acting on this belief would use race as a low-cost signal to filter requests, prioritizing White investors under the assumption they are more likely to represent significant capital. Similar economic logic applies to gender. IR professionals may use gender as a proxy for access to capital or investment sophistication. Such beliefs could draw on well-documented economic disparities: the gender wage gap shows that women earn approximately 84 cents for every dollar earned by

men (e.g., Blau and Kahn, 2017), and women hold significantly less financial wealth than men on average (e.g., Chang, 2010).

This logic generates a clear, testable prediction: if the observed racial disparity is driven by statistical discrimination related to beliefs about access to capital, it should attenuate when the IR professional receives a stronger, more direct signal of the investor's economic value. As we discuss in Section 3, our professional investor manipulation is designed to be such a signal. The custom email domain, corporate signature, and professional website are intended to convey greater sophistication and access to capital. Therefore, if statistical discrimination is the primary mechanism, the gap in meeting access between investors should be smaller in our professional condition than in our retail investor condition.

2.3.2 Taste-Based Discrimination in the Investor Relations Setting

In contrast, taste-based discrimination would occur if an IR professional has an intrinsic preference for interacting with one group over another, independent of any beliefs about their economic value. This preference could manifest as animus toward an out-group or a preference for interacting with individuals who share one's own identity (in-group preference). For example, given that the majority of IR professionals are estimated to be White and male (see Table 6), such behavior could lead to preferential treatment of White and male investors.

This theory also generates a testable prediction, but one that is distinct from that of statistical discrimination: if observed disparities are driven by taste-based discrimination, it should persist regardless of signals about the investor's economic value to the firm. An IR professional with a taste-based preference would not view the professional investor signal as a substitute for race; their preference would be unrelated to the investor's sophistication or capital. Therefore, if taste-based discrimination is the primary mechanism, the gap in meeting access between

demographic groups should remain constant across both the retail and professional investor conditions.

2.3.3 Assumptions and Limitations

While our experimental approach avoids the omitted variables bias that plagues observational studies by allowing us to independently randomize signals that are not possible in archival studies (Guryan and Charles, 2013), our ability to distinguish between statistical and taste-based mechanisms relies on a key assumption: that our professional investor manipulation serves as a credible signal of higher economic value that is capable of updating an IR professional's prior beliefs. The power of our test is limited if this assumption does not hold. For instance, an IR professional could conduct a search and determine that our fictitious firms are not registered with the SEC and dismiss the signal as non-credible.

Furthermore, a null result for the interaction between investor type and a demographic characteristic must be interpreted with care. The signal of professionalism does not counteract every stereotype at play. An IR professional might use a demographic trait as a proxy for a characteristic that does not vary with investor professionalism. In these cases, our manipulation may not address the specific belief driving statistical discrimination. Moreover, beliefs like these may not fit cleanly into either theoretical framework: if IR professionals associate race or gender with lower investment competence, it is unclear whether this reflects an informational inference about economic value (statistical discrimination) or an ingrained stereotype more akin to a preference (taste-based discrimination). Consequently, our experiment is not designed to definitively prove or disprove one theory. Instead, it allows us to test for patterns in the data that are more or less consistent with each mechanism, and we interpret our findings with this limitation in mind.

3. Experimental Design

We conduct a pre-registered $2 \times 2 \times 2$ between-subjects field experiment, manipulating fictitious investor *Race* (Black-sounding vs White-sounding name), *Gender* (female-sounding vs male-sounding name), and *Investor Type* (retail vs professional investor) in email requests to internal IR departments of U.S. public companies. For free email domains, we follow the format first.last{###}@domainname.com, where {###} is a randomly generated three-digit number to ensure email uniqueness. For professional investor email domains, we omit the randomly generated numbers to improve construct validity.⁶ We manipulate *Race* and *Gender* via first and last names and *Investor Type* through a combination of email domain, email signature, and a website for the investment firm in the case of professional investors.

Field experiments offer an attractive method to investigate our research questions. As Floyd and List [2016] note, field experiments combine the scientific rigor of randomization with the realism of naturally occurring settings, allowing researchers to draw causal inferences while maintaining high external validity. This approach enables us to directly observe and measure real-world behaviors of IR professionals in their natural environment, providing insights that may be difficult to obtain through other methodologies. Moreover, field experiments can overcome potential biases associated with laboratory studies or survey-based research, such as demand effects, social desirability bias, self-reporting inaccuracies, and Treatment Specific Selection Bias (Al-Ubaydli and List, 2015; Paluck and Shafir, 2017). Thus, our research design allows us to unobtrusively isolate the effects of race, gender, and investor type on the likelihood of securing a meeting with corporate insiders, while random assignment controls for other factors that might influence IR responsiveness.

⁶ Investors at professional investment firms are unlikely to need to distinguish their email from peers at the same firm with the use of numbers or symbols.

3.1 Sample Selection and Randomization

Our sample comprises IR departments of U.S. public companies that disclose an IR email address in their most recent earnings press release. We construct this sample through the following process, detailed in Table 1: (1) We obtain the universe of U.S. public companies at the intersection of Compustat and CRSP databases from WRDS SEC Analytics listed on the NYSE, AMEX, or NASDAQ; (2) For each company, we download the most recent earnings press release and extract all email addresses contained therein; (3) We manually verify each extracted email address is associated with the IR department by examining the surrounding text; (4) We remove IR contacts that are not company insiders (Volant, 2025). This approach ensures a comprehensive and current sample of accessible IR departments.

We employ a stratified randomization procedure to assign companies to one of our eight experimental conditions. We base this stratification on three factors that potentially influence the likelihood of IR responding and granting a meeting request: (1) market capitalization, as it may affect resources dedicated to IR activities and sophistication of response protocols, potentially mitigating overt discrimination in larger firms; (2) IR email type (personalized or general), as it likely indicates the level of personal engagement in investor communications, with personalized emails possibly leading to more individualized responses;⁷ and (3) retail ownership percentage (1 minus institutional ownership), as it could affect a firm’s approach to individual investors, reducing the likelihood of discrimination against non-professional investors.⁸ By stratifying across these factors, we ensure balance across experimental conditions on these potentially important

⁷ Call et al. (2024) find that a personal email address is the strongest predictor of response rate in their survey of corporate executives.

⁸ We implement the stratified randomization procedure by stratifying firms into deciles based on market capitalization and retail ownership percentage and ensuring that each condition has approximately the same number of observations from each decile. IR email type, which only has two groupings, is also balanced across conditions. As we discuss in Section 4.1, the means of each continuous variable are not statistically different across manipulations.

determinants of investor relations responses, increasing the internal validity of our design and our ability to detect potential discriminatory practices.

3.2 Race and Gender

We manipulate investor race and gender perceptions through the use of racially- and gender-distinctive names in email addresses. This approach builds on a well-established methodology in discrimination research (e.g., Bertrand and Mullainathan, 2004; Kline et al., 2022). We focus on Black versus White investors, as this comparison has consistently revealed the most pronounced discriminatory behaviors in various economic contexts in the United States (e.g., Bartlett et al., 2022; Bertrand and Mullainathan, 2004; Egan et al., 2022; Charles and Guryan, 2008; Lyons-Padilla et al., 2019; Pager and Shepherd, 2008).

Our name selection process draws from the set used by Kline et al. (2022), which incorporates names from Bertrand and Mullainathan (2004) and administrative records from the North Carolina Administrative Office of the Courts. For each race-gender combination, we select three first names that appear in both Bertrand and Mullainathan (2004) and Kline et al. (2022), ensuring strong racial and gender associations. The first names are: Aisha, Latoya, and Tamika (Black female); Jamal, Kareem, and Tyrone (Black male); Emily, Jill, and Kristen (White female); and Brad, Brendan, and Matthew (White male). For last names, we select three racially distinctive surnames for each racial group from Kline et al. (2022). Our selection criteria balance both race share (the proportion of individuals with that surname who are either Black or White) and frequency of occurrence in the population. For Black surnames, we use Pierre, Smalls, and Washington; for White surnames, we use Larson, Olson, and Schmidt. These surnames exhibit high race share while also occurring frequently in the population. Combining these first and last

names leads to 36 unique name combinations (9 for each race-gender pair) for use in our email addresses.

We use compound manipulations, where names signal multiple demographic characteristics simultaneously. This design choice enhances the external validity of our study (Floyd and List, 2016), reflecting the complex nature of demographic signals in the real world. By allowing associated perceptions to vary naturally with our manipulations, we capture the aggregate effect of race and gender signals on IR departments' responses, aligning with recent developments in experimental methods that emphasize studying discrimination in its naturalistic complexity (Bertrand and Duflo, 2017).

3.3 Investor Professionalism Manipulation

We manipulate investor type through email domains representing potential real-world investment companies. For the retail investor condition, we use common email providers (e.g., gmail.com, yahoo.com, and outlook.com).⁹ For the professional investor condition, we create domains for fictitious investment firms (e.g., bluewillowcapital.com, fusionpointequities.com, and globalviewsinvestments.com) supported by professionally designed websites (see Appendix C for a full list of experimental conditions). To mitigate domain-specific biases, we randomize the use of specific domains within each condition.

Our investor type manipulation involves several key considerations. First, independent research by IR departments in the professional investor condition could reveal that neither the investor nor the investment firm is registered with the SEC.¹⁰ However, prior research suggests

⁹ Kline et al. (2022) conduct a large-scale field experiment examining discrimination in job applications. They varied email domains across experimental conditions: 50% of applicants used common free email services (@gmail.com, @yahoo.com, and @outlook.com), while the other 50% used custom domains (@icloudlive.me, @spectrumemail.org, @fiosmail.net, and @xfinity19.com). Through personal communication with Kline et al., we confirmed that they observed no significant differences in outcomes between the freely available and custom email domains.

¹⁰ Given this setup, we expect that any differential access we observe represents a lower bound on a true disparity between retail and professional investors.

that IR departments rarely conduct such in-depth investigations, and even if some departments do screen, a significant proportion of email requests receive a response (Heinrichs, 2014). Second, our investor type manipulation is inherently compound, reflecting the differences that exist in the real world between retail and professional investors. Relative to professional investors, it is likely IROs will perceive retail investors as being less sophisticated and having lower access to capital.

The professional investors in our experimental condition are not recognizable brand names like Vanguard or BlackRock. Instead, our manipulation is designed to represent the “long tail” of the investment industry, the thousands of small and mid-sized investment advisers and boutique firms operating in the U.S. By signaling a professional firm structure, a dedicated website, and a corporate domain, we test whether the signal of being an “institutional” rather than “individual” market participant mitigates discrimination. This allows us to draw inferences about the broad middle market of professional investors, a segment where information access is important for competition. Further, this manipulation allows us to draw inferences about differential information access between retail and professional investors that closely mirrors real-world conditions.

3.4 Experimental Procedure

We randomly assign companies in our sample to one of eight experimental conditions, subject to balance on the variables discussed previously, using the ‘randtreat’ Stata package. Each condition is associated with nine specific email addresses. To maximize the response rate, we launched the field experiment on Monday, December 9th, between corporate earnings seasons (after 12/31 year-end firms have announced Q3 earnings but before the end of Q4). This timing is outside most companies’ black-out period, reducing the chance that companies do not respond due to company policy. Given our sample of 2,731 target email addresses, we sent approximately 38

emails from each of our 72 experimental email addresses. To reduce potential time-of-day effects, we randomize the intraday timing of email transmissions.

Our primary experimental intervention involves contacting IR departments to request one-on-one meetings to discuss recent earnings results. This approach involves several key considerations. First, prior research indicates that IR departments are generally receptive to meeting requests from firm investors, suggesting sufficient variation in our dependent variable (Laskin, 2009; Heinrichs, 2014). Second, one-on-one meetings offer a richer information environment than email exchanges, as they allow for the interpretation of vocal cues and tones, which have been shown to be informative (e.g., Mayew and Venkatachalam, 2012). Third, by framing our request around a broad topic (earnings results) we maintain a more universally applicable and consistent template compared to specific questions tailored to the company. This approach allows us to include a diverse range of publicly traded companies in our sample, avoiding the exclusion of firms with unique business models (e.g., pre-revenue biopharma companies). Appendix B presents the email templates for both the retail and professional investor conditions, which we reproduce the body of here:

[Retail Investor]: *I hope this message finds you well. My name is [Investor Name]. I am considering investing in your company, and I would appreciate the opportunity to discuss some aspects of your recent earnings release. If possible, I'd like to schedule a brief call at your convenience to address a few questions regarding your financials. When would you be available for a call in the next two weeks?*

Thank you for your time and I look forward to your response.

[Professional Investor]: *I hope this message finds you well. My name is [Investor Name], and I work at [Investment Firm Name]. We are considering investing in your company, and I would appreciate the opportunity to discuss some aspects of your recent earnings release. If possible, I'd like to schedule a brief call at your convenience to address a few questions regarding your financials. When would you be available for a call in the next two weeks?*

Thank you for your time and I look forward to your response.

Our email requests a ‘brief call’ with the IR contact, consistent with how investors typically initiate engagement with IR departments. We note that the resulting approvals varied in form: some IR professionals offered a phone call, others proposed an in-person meeting, and several offered access to senior management including C-suite executives (analyzed separately in Section 4.2.3). In our pre-registration, we planned for four possible broad outcomes to the initial email: (1) a favorable response indicating a willingness to meet, (2) a request for more information without granting or denying a meeting, (3) an unwillingness to meet, or (4) no response. Our follow-up protocol varied by outcome. For favorable responses or requests for more information (outcomes 1 and 2), we sent a follow-up email expressing gratitude for their response and indicating that a call was no longer necessary. For explicit denials (outcome 3), we did not respond further to minimize burden on IR departments.¹¹

3.5 Deception

Our experimental design relies on deception: we created fictitious investor identities and contacted IR professionals under those identities (Libby and Salterio, 2019). We acknowledge that deception raises important ethical considerations and address these directly. We believe deception was a necessary design choice for three reasons. First, studying potential discrimination in investor access requires observing the actual behavior of IR professionals in response to requests that vary only in the demographic characteristics of the requester. Surveys or interviews on this topic would likely suffer from social desirability bias (Krosnick, 1999; Levitt and List, 2007) and be ineffective at capturing implicit bias, as respondents themselves may be unaware of their own discriminatory

¹¹ Our implemented response protocol differs slightly from our pre-registration plan due to the logistics of tracking more than 2,700 sent emails over 72 email accounts in real-time, without introducing unrandomized differences across conditions, being infeasible. In the pre-registration plan, we planned to follow-up with non-responders by sending a brief reminder email and with outcome (2) by sending an email emphasizing a preference for a phone call.

behaviors. Second, alternative non-deceptive approaches, such as requesting that IR professionals self-report their decision-making criteria, would not produce the revealed-preference data necessary for causal identification. Third, the use of deception is consistent with the well-established correspondence testing methodology used to study labor markets (Bertrand and Mullainathan, 2004; Kline et al., 2022), housing (Edelman et al., 2017), and academic settings (Milkman et al., 2015), where deception is generally regarded as a necessary feature of the research design given the inability to otherwise observe discriminatory behavior.

Our study received IRB approval from the authors' respective institutions prior to data collection, and our study includes several design features meant to mitigate potential harms. We minimized the burden on IR professionals by promptly canceling all scheduled meetings upon receiving a positive response, limiting each participant's involvement to reading and responding to a single, brief email. No actual meetings took place. Based on discussions with former IR professionals, the email templates (Appendix B) are standard requests that IR departments routinely receive and our experimental procedure is unlikely to impose costs beyond those of ordinary business correspondence. We recognize that IR professionals who encounter this research may view the use of fictitious identities as a breach of professional trust. However, accounting research has a long tradition of examining corporate practices that firms may prefer not to have scrutinized, such as earnings management or stock-option backdating, and the academic value of understanding these phenomena is widely recognized despite the discomfort they may cause to firms and managers. Similarly, understanding whether discriminatory barriers exist in corporate information access requires methodologies that may be uncomfortable for participants but are necessary to illuminate otherwise unobservable behavior.

We believe the social value of identifying such barriers, barriers that are otherwise unobservable, justifies the deception involved. Policies, regulations, and laws addressing discrimination are not created absent evidence of the behaviors they seek to remedy, and evidence of this kind has historically played a direct role in shaping real-world policy responses. Bertrand and Mullainathan's (2004) study of racial discrimination in hiring, for example, has been entered into Congressional testimony, informed EEOC enforcement discussions, and contributed to the empirical foundation for name-blind recruitment initiatives subsequently adopted by government and private firms (see, e.g., EEOC, 2006; Behaghel et al., 2015; Bohnet, 2016; Hiscox et al., 2017). By providing evidence that racial and gender characteristics may influence access to corporate insiders, our findings will shed light on practices that are otherwise hidden from regulators, policymakers, and market participants, potentially informing future investor protection regulations, IR disclosure requirements, or corporate governance standards. Consistent with the ethical standards of the American Psychological Association (Standard 8.07), we employ deception only because the study's significant prospective scientific and societal value cannot be achieved through feasible nondeceptive alternatives, and we conclude that these anticipated benefits outweigh the minimal risks imposed on participants.

4. Results

This section presents the empirical findings from our pre-registered field experiment. We first confirm the validity of our randomization procedure, followed by the primary analyses examining the effects of investor race, gender, and type on access to corporate insiders. Finally, we explore potential heterogeneity in these effects through cross-sectional analyses.

4.1 Covariate Balance

A prerequisite for drawing causal inferences from our experimental design is the successful randomization of firms across treatment conditions. Table 2 presents results from OLS regressions testing for balance on our stratification variables: market capitalization decile, the use of a personal versus generic IR email address, and retail ownership decile.¹² Across all specifications, the coefficients on the indicator variables for each of the seven treatment arms (relative to the White professional male baseline) are statistically indistinguishable from zero.¹³ This confirms that our stratified randomization procedure effectively balanced key firm characteristics that could potentially confound our results.

4.2 Main Analyses

4.2.1. Willingness to Schedule a Meeting

Our primary research question investigates whether IR departments exhibit differential responsiveness based on perceived investor race or gender. We first examine the likelihood of securing any meeting. We present descriptive statistics in Table 3, Panel A, which shows variation across conditions. For context, the overall meeting approval rate was 16.3%. Aggregating across gender and investor type, White investors received meeting offers at a rate of 18.3%, compared to 14.4% for Black investors. At the univariate level, this suggests that White investors had roughly 27% higher probability of securing a meeting based on these proportions. In contrast, the descriptive statistics show minimal differences in meeting rates between female (16.5%) and male (16.2%) investors, or between retail (15.8%) and professional (16.8%) investors (aggregated values untabulated).

¹² There is missing size and retail ownership data for 12 and 207 observations, respectively (out of 2,731). These missing observations were balanced across conditions.

¹³ We present univariate covariate balance across conditions in IA Table 1 and continue to find no differences.

To formally test these differences, we estimate the logistic regression model specified in Equation (1):

$$\begin{aligned} \Pr(\textit{Meeting}_i) = & \beta_0 + \beta_1\textit{Black} + \beta_2\textit{Female} + \beta_3\textit{Retail} + \\ & \beta_4\textit{Black} * \textit{Female} + \beta_5\textit{Black} * \textit{Retail} + \beta_6\textit{Female} * \textit{Retail} + \\ & \beta_7\textit{Black} * \textit{Female} * \textit{Retail} + \varepsilon_i \end{aligned} \quad (1)$$

Our primary dependent variable, *Meeting*, captures whether the IR department agreed to a call or meeting with the investor, consistent with the range of positive responses received. *Black*, *Female*, and *Retail* are indicator variables for the Black, female, and retail treatment conditions, respectively. Throughout our analyses, we use robust standard errors, as our outcomes are measured at the same granularity as treatment assignment.

Table 3, Panel B, presents the results. Column 1 displays the average treatment effects. The coefficient on *Black* is negative and statistically significant ($-0.292, p < 0.01$). The odds ratio of 0.747 indicates that the likelihood of a Black investor being granted a meeting is approximately 25% lower than that of an otherwise identical White investor. Equivalently, the odds of a White investor securing a meeting are approximately 34% higher than those for a Black investor. This provides clear evidence of a racial disparity disadvantaging Black investors in accessing corporate insiders. To place this magnitude in context, we note that the effect size we document is within the range observed in other correspondence studies of discrimination in financial and professional settings. Bertrand and Mullainathan (2004) report that White-sounding names receive approximately 50% more callbacks than Black-sounding names in a labor market experiment. Kline et al. (2022) find that distinctively Black names receive 8.5% fewer callbacks from large U.S. employers.

In contrast, the coefficient on *Female* (0.022, $p > 0.10$) is small and statistically insignificant, suggesting no discernible difference in meeting access based on gender. Similarly, the coefficient on *Retail* (-0.073, $p > 0.10$) is statistically insignificant, indicating that, within the context of our manipulation, perceived investor type does not significantly affect the likelihood of being granted a meeting. This finding suggests that IR departments may be more receptive to unknown retail investors than commonly assumed, at least at the initial point of contact. We emphasize, however, that our professional investor condition represents unrecognized boutique firms, not established institutional investors with whom IR departments have existing relationships. The null result for investor type therefore speaks to the margin between retail investors and small, unfamiliar professional investors, and does not address the access advantage for well-known institutional investors documented in prior research (e.g., Solomon and Soltes, 2015; Brown et al., 2019).

Column 2 of Table 3, Panel B, presents the results from the fully interacted model. None of the interaction terms (two-way or three-way) are statistically significant. This indicates that the observed racial disparity disadvantaging Black investors does not significantly differ based on the investor's gender or perceived professional status. This pattern is consistent with what one would expect under taste-based discrimination, in which preferences are unrelated to investor sophistication. However, as we discuss in Section 2.3.3, this inference depends on the assumption that our professional investor manipulation was perceived as a credible signal of higher economic value. The absence of a statistically significant interaction is also consistent with statistical discrimination if IR professionals did not perceive a meaningful difference in sophistication between our retail and boutique professional conditions. We therefore interpret this evidence as suggestive, and we remain agnostic about the precise mechanism. Nonetheless, while we are

cautious in drawing conclusions about the precise mechanism, our results demonstrate that perceived race is an important causal determinant in investors gaining access to corporate insiders.¹⁴

4.2.2 Firm Responsiveness

To provide a more nuanced understanding of IR engagement beyond the binary meeting outcome, we analyze *Responsiveness*, our pre-registered secondary outcome coded on an ordinal scale: 0 (no response), 1 (responds but is not willing to talk nor makes an effort to answer questions via email), 2 (responds and is unwilling to schedule a call but is willing to answer questions via email), and 3 (agrees to a meeting). When we examine the distribution of *Responsiveness*, we find (untabulated) that the responses are concentrated at the extremes: either agreeing to a meeting (16%) or not responding (81%), with significantly fewer instances falling into the intermediate categories of being unwilling to answer any questions (2%) or unwilling to meet but willing to answer questions via email (1%). Descriptive statistics in Table 4, Panel A, show each condition's mean and standard deviation for *Responsiveness*. The means mirror the patterns observed for *Meeting*, with White investors generally having higher average responsiveness scores than Black investors, while differences across gender and investor type appear minimal.

We estimate the ordered logistic regression model specified in Equation (2) to formally test the effects of our manipulations on this ordinal outcome:¹⁵

$$\begin{aligned} Responsiveness_i = & \beta_0 + \beta_1 Black + \beta_2 Female + \beta_3 Retail + \\ & \beta_4 Black * Female + \beta_5 Black * Retail + \beta_6 Female * Retail + \end{aligned}$$

¹⁴ All of the discussed results are robust to estimating Equation (1) with the inclusion of the covariate balance variables as controls as well as using OLS.

¹⁵ Our pre-registration document specified that Equation (2) be estimated using OLS. Since then, due to the ordinal nature of the variable, we concluded that ordered logistic regression is more appropriate and have thus included this specification in the main draft. However, we have also tabulated the results of Equation (2) in the internet appendix as IA Table 2 using OLS. All inferences using OLS are unchanged from those using ordered logistic regression.

$$\beta_7 \text{Black} * \text{Female} * \text{Retail} + \varepsilon_i \quad (2)$$

Table 4, Panel B presents the results. Consistent with the *Meeting* analysis, the coefficient on *Black* in column 1 (-0.190, $p < 0.10$) is negative and statistically significant at the 10% level, indicating that Black investors have lower odds of receiving higher levels of responsiveness compared to White investors. The coefficients for *Female* (0.116, $p > 0.10$) and *Retail* (0.068, $p > 0.10$) remain statistically insignificant.

The fully interacted model in Column 2 of Table 4, Panel B, again shows no significant interaction effects. The negative association between the Black investor condition and IR responsiveness persists across gender and investor type. Thus, the *Responsiveness* results corroborate the findings from the primary *Meeting* analysis: investor race is a significant factor influencing IR engagement, with Black investors experiencing systematically lower levels of access and responsiveness, and this effect is not significantly moderated by gender or perceived professionalism.¹⁶

4.2.3. Willingness to Schedule a Meeting with C-Suite Executive

We further investigate the nature of access by examining another pre-registered variable of interest: conditional on being offered any meeting, whether the investor is offered time with a C-suite executive (*C-Suite Meeting*).¹⁷ This analysis uses the subsample of 433 requests where a meeting was initially granted. Table 5, Panel A, displays the proportion of requests within each condition that resulted in a C-suite meeting offer.

¹⁶ All of the discussed results are robust to estimating Equation (2) with the inclusion of the covariate balance variables as controls as well as using OLS.

¹⁷ Our operationalization of this variable differs slightly from our pre-registration document. We pre-registered that this variable would be ordered based on job title. However, upon reading the email responses, we observed a lack of standardization in job titles across firms, hindering our ability to both execute our planned analysis and draw meaningful inferences from it. However, to capture a similar construct, we evaluate whether a firm offers the investor a meeting with a C-suite executive, as these titles are more systematic across firms.

Table 5, Panel B presents the logistic regression results based on Equation (3) for this subsample:

$$\begin{aligned} \Pr(C - Suite Meeting_i) = & \beta_0 + \beta_1 Black + \beta_2 Female + \beta_3 Retail + \\ & \beta_4 Black * Female + \beta_5 Black * Retail + \beta_6 Female * Retail + \\ & \beta_7 Black * Female * Retail + \varepsilon_i \end{aligned} \quad (3)$$

In Column 1 (average treatment effects), the coefficient for *Black* (0.582, $p > 0.10$) is positive but not statistically significant, suggesting that *among those granted a meeting*, Black investors are not significantly less likely than White investors to be offered access to a C-suite executive (0.582, $p > 0.10$). However, the coefficient for *Female* (-0.978, $p < 0.05$) is negative and statistically significant. The odds ratio (0.376) indicates that the odds of a female investor being offered a C-suite meeting are lower than those for an otherwise identical male investor, conditional on securing an initial meeting. The coefficient for *Retail* (0.015, $p > 0.10$) remains insignificant.

The fully interacted model in Column 2 shows no significant interaction effects. It is important to note that the *Female* coefficient in this specification captures the effect of being a white, professional female investor (i.e., the group not captured by the interaction terms in the model) and not the average treatment effect of being a female investor. The average treatment effect of being female is shown in Column 1 and is unchanged by including a fully specified model.

These findings present a more complex picture than the initial access results. The absence of a racial disparity for C-suite access, conditional on getting a meeting, suggests that once an initial positive screening occurs (where the primary racial bias seems to operate), the decision of *who* takes the meeting does not appear to be influenced by race. However, the disadvantage for female investors in accessing C-suite executives contrasts with the lack of gender bias for general meeting access. This could potentially reflect persistent stereotypes about gender roles in high-

level corporate interactions, differential allocation by gatekeepers (e.g., executive assistants), or perhaps perceived differences in the seriousness or nature of inquiries based on gender, even with identical email text.

In our internet appendix (IA Table 3), we also tabulate the time elapsed between the initial email send time and the first non-automated response from the firm. When we analyze response times using OLS, we find that White investors received slower responses. However, this result is driven by outlier observations, as validated using quantile regression, in which we find no statistically significant difference in response times across experimental groups. These outliers are ultimately due to White investors receiving email responses multiple weeks after their initial email send date but before our experimental cutoff date.¹⁸

4.3 Cross-Sectional Analyses

To deepen our understanding of the factors that influence IR departments' responses to investor inquiries, we explore how several characteristics moderate the effects observed in our analyses. We investigate moderation by firm size (market capitalization), retail ownership percentage, and the estimated race and gender of the IR professional contacted. It is important to note that analyses involving firm size were not pre-registered, while those involving retail ownership and IR professional demographics were.¹⁹

Before examining potential moderation effects, we note the demographic characteristics of the IR professionals in our sample, as estimated using Namsor, a commercial gender, race, and

¹⁸ Our pre-registration document specified analyzing the business hours between initial contact and the earliest proposed meeting time, which we did not ultimately examine because many firms asked for the investor's availability without proposing a specific time. To reduce the costs of our experiment on IR resources, we did not pursue additional back-and-forth messages for this secondary outcome variable. This factor rendered this measure inapplicable or unreliable for a large portion of observations where meetings were offered, limiting the ability to draw inferences.

¹⁹ Analyses related to pre-registered C-suite and board diversity moderators were performed but are not tabulated due to substantially reduced sample sizes (limited data coverage for diversity metrics) leading to low statistical power, making it difficult to distinguish null effects from Type II errors.

origin classification algorithm, that has been identified as the most accurate commercially available tool (Alexopoulos et al., 2024; Sebo, 2021). Specifically, we tabulate the race and gender the algorithm estimates as being most likely in Table 6. All of our qualitative inferences in this paper using the estimated race and gender of IR professionals are unchanged if we use a more conservative approach that requires the algorithm to be at least 80% confident. The majority of contacts are estimated to be White (54%) and male (75%). Minority representation includes individuals estimated as Black (28%), Asian (7%), and Hispanic/Latino (11%). This distribution differs from the sell-side analyst population documented in Flam et al. (2023), where Hispanic or Latino individuals constitute the second-largest ethnic minority group, indicating that demographic composition varies across financial market roles.

4.3.1 Cross-Sectional Analyses of Meeting Likelihood

Table 7 presents cross-sectional analyses examining how firm and IR professional characteristics moderate the effects of investor race, gender, and type on the likelihood of being offered a meeting (*Meeting*).

In Panel A (firm characteristics), we split the sample based on the median value of retail ownership (Columns 1-2) and market capitalization (Columns 3-4). Examining the retail ownership split, the coefficients for *Black*, *Female*, and *Retail* are not significantly different between firms with low versus high retail ownership. Although the difference between low and high retail ownership firms is statistically insignificant, we note that *Black* is insignificant for low retail ownership firms ($-0.166, p > 0.10$) and statistically significant for high retail ownership firms ($-0.385, p < 0.05$). These results generally suggest the firm's existing retail investor base does not significantly alter how IR departments grant initial meeting access based on our manipulated investor characteristics.

Examining the firm size split, the negative coefficient for *Black* is statistically significant in both small ($-0.256, p < 0.10$) and large ($-0.326, p < 0.05$) firms, with no significant difference between them, indicating that the racial disparity persists regardless of firm size. The *Female* coefficient is negative and statistically insignificant for small firms ($-0.232, p > 0.10$) but positive and statistically significant for large firms ($0.246, p < 0.10$), with the difference between the two also being statistically significant ($0.478, p < 0.05$). This suggests female investors may face a slight disadvantage at small firms that is reversed at large firms. *Retail* is not significantly moderated by firm size nor statistically significant within either subgroup.

In Panel B (IR professional characteristics), we split the sample based on the estimated race (Minority vs. White, Columns 1-2) and gender (female vs. male, Columns 3-4) of the IR professional. Examining the IR race split, the negative *Black* coefficient is statistically significant for both minority ($-0.320, p < 0.10$) and White ($-0.285, p < 0.05$) IR professionals, with no significant difference between the groups. This result is consistent with the intuition in the economics literature recognizing that in-group favoritism is not the only expression of bias; minority decision-makers may internalize dominant-group norms or face institutional pressures that constrain their individual discretion (e.g., Aigner and Cain, 1977).

The *Female* and *Retail* estimates are not significant across minority and White IR professionals nor within each subgroup. Examining IR estimated gender, the negative *Black* coefficient is statistically significant for male IR professionals ($-0.321, p < 0.01$) and directionally similar, though not significant, for female IR professionals ($-0.227, p > 0.10$), with no significant difference between the groups. Again, the *Female* and *Retail* estimates are not significant across female and male IR professionals nor within each subgroup. Overall, these findings suggest that the racial disparity in meeting access is generally robust across firm sizes, retail ownership levels,

and IR professional demographics. Further, firm size significantly moderates the gender effect, with large firms being relatively more receptive to female investors than small firms.

4.3.2 Cross-Sectional Analyses of Investor Relations Responsiveness

Table 8 examines moderation effects on the broader *Responsiveness* measure. The findings largely parallel those for meeting likelihood. We do not find that the lower responsiveness to Black investors is statistically different across firm retail ownership (Panel A, Columns 1-2), firm size (Panel A, Columns 3-4), or the estimated race (Panel B, Columns 1-2) or gender (Panel B, Columns 3-4) of the IR professional. While the differences across subgroups based on these characteristics are not statistically significant, the negative coefficient for *Black* reaches conventional significance levels in the following subgroups: high retail investor ownership ($-0.301, p < 0.05$), large firms ($-0.263, p < 0.10$), and male IR professionals ($-0.240, p < 0.05$). Consistent with our meeting results, we find that firm size moderates the gender effect, with large firms showing significantly higher responsiveness towards female investors compared to small firms (Panel A, Columns 3-4, difference $p < 0.01$). Neither retail ownership levels nor IR professional characteristics significantly moderate the effects of investor gender or type on IR responsiveness.

4.3.3 Cross-Sectional Analyses of Meeting with C-Suite Executive

Table 9 presents moderation analyses for the likelihood of being offered a C-suite meeting, conditional on receiving a meeting offer. We caution that these results should be interpreted carefully due to the smaller sample size of the conditional analysis.²⁰ Considering this limitation, we find no statistically significant evidence that firm characteristics (retail ownership or size, Panel

²⁰ Due to the conditional nature of this dependent variable as well as the decreased sample sizes due to cross-sectional splits, these analyses have lower power than analyses examining previous outcome variables. Additionally, since there are no instances in our data where a female IR professional offers a female investor a meeting with a C-suite executive, logistic regression cannot estimate a coefficient for *Female*. Thus, Columns 3 and 4 in Panel B are estimated using ordinary least squares (OLS) as indicated in the estimation method row of the table. Our inferences for *Black* and *Retail* are unchanged from our OLS inferences if estimated using logistic regression without including *Female*.

A) or IR professional characteristics (race or gender, Panel B) moderate the effects of investor race, gender, or type on the probability of securing access to a C-suite executive. The overall disadvantage for female investors in obtaining C-suite access, identified in Table 5, does not show statistically significant variation across these subgroups, though power constraints may obscure subtle differences. Similarly, we do not detect any significant moderation effects for the *Black* or *Retail* coefficient estimates.

5. Conclusion

This study provides causal evidence on discrimination in investor access to corporate insiders through a pre-registered field experiment. By systematically manipulating investor race, gender, and type in 2,731 meeting requests to U.S. public companies' investor relations departments, we document significant disparities in access, or lack thereof, that have important implications for market fairness and efficiency. Our primary finding reveals that Black investors face substantially higher barriers to accessing corporate insiders than White investors, with White investors being 34% more likely to secure meetings. This racial disparity does not differ across investor type, firm characteristics, or IR professional demographics. While the persistence of the racial disparity across investor types is consistent with taste-based discrimination, we cannot rule out that our professional investor manipulation was insufficient to attenuate statistical discrimination. We therefore do not draw definitive conclusions about the underlying mechanism and instead note that the observed patterns are more consistent with some theoretical explanations than others. Nonetheless, while we are cautious in drawing conclusions about the precise mechanism, our results demonstrate that perceived race is an important causal determinant in investors gaining access to corporate insiders.

While we find no evidence of gender discrimination in initial meeting access, a more nuanced pattern emerges when examining the quality of access granted. Female investors who successfully secure meetings are less likely than male investors to be offered time with C-suite executives. This finding suggests that discrimination can manifest at different stages of the IR process, with gender-based barriers emerging after initial screening. Contrary to conventional wisdom, we find no significant differences in meeting access between retail and professional investors, challenging the assumption that investor status alone determines access.

Our findings are subject to several caveats. First, it is possible that our findings reflect IR practices during a specific period in U.S. markets and may not generalize to other time periods or jurisdictions, particularly given evolving social attitudes and corporate policies regarding diversity and inclusion. Second, while we made efforts to create legitimate fictitious identities for professional investors, including developing company websites and securing paid email domains, IR representatives may have identified these as non-authentic, potentially affecting our results for the main effect of investor type. Third, our findings regarding investor type likely generalize to boutique investment firms and individual investors but may not extend to massive asset managers with established corporate relationships (e.g., Vanguard, BlackRock, Citadel). Finally, while we document systematic differences in access across racial categories, we cannot definitively determine whether these disparities stem from individual IR representative decisions or reflect broader institutional practices. Despite these limitations, we believe our study offers novel evidence on the role of individual characteristics in determining access to corporate insiders and contributes to our understanding of potential barriers to information acquisition in financial markets.

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Appendix A Variable Definitions

<i>Variable</i>	<i>Definition</i>
<i>Black</i>	An indicator variable for the experimental condition where the fictitious investor is Black.
<i>C-Suite Meeting</i>	An indicator variable equal to one if the firm offers to make a C-suite executive available to meet with the investor and zero otherwise (conditional on being offered any meeting).
<i>Female</i>	An indicator variable for the experimental condition where the fictitious investor is female.
<i>IR Contact Gender</i>	The estimated gender of the investor relations professionals named as the primary investor contact in our sample. Gender is estimated using the United States Namsor API, a machine learning algorithm used to estimate the gender of an individual based on first and last name. The tabulated estimates are using the algorithm's most likely gender estimate.
<i>IR Contact Race</i>	The estimated race of the investor relations professionals named as the primary investor contact in our sample. The race is estimated using the United States Namsor API, a machine learning algorithm used to estimate the race of an individual based on first and last name. The tabulated estimates are using the algorithm's most likely race estimate.
<i>Market Capitalization</i>	The total market value of a company's outstanding shares at the end of the previous quarter.
<i>Meeting</i>	An indicator variable that equals 1 if the investor relations representative agreed to meet with the fictional investor and 0 otherwise.
<i>Responsiveness</i>	An ordered variable taking values from 0 to 3, capturing the level of IR responsiveness: 3 = Company responds and is willing to schedule a call; 2 = Company responds and is unwilling to schedule a call but answers questions via email; 1 = Company responds but is unwilling to talk or answer questions via email; 0 = Company does not respond within 14 days of initial contact and follow-up procedures.
<i>Retail</i>	An indicator variable for the experimental condition where the fictitious investor is presented as a retail investor.
<i>Retail Ownership</i>	The percentage of the company's shares owned by individual (non-institutional) investors, measured as one less the share of institutional investors.

Appendix B Email Template

Panel A: Retail Investor Template

Subject: Request for Meeting

Dear [IR Contact Name],

I hope this message finds you well. My name is [Investor Name]. I am considering investing in your company, and I would appreciate the opportunity to discuss some aspects of your recent earnings release. If possible, I'd like to schedule a brief call at your convenience to address a few questions regarding your financials. When would you be available for a call in the next two weeks?

Thank you for your time and I look forward to your response.

[Investor Name]

Panel B: Professional Investor Template

Subject: Request for Meeting

Dear [IR Contact Name],

I hope this message finds you well. My name is [Investor Name], and I work at [Investment Firm Name]. We are considering investing in your company, and I would appreciate the opportunity to discuss some aspects of your recent earnings release. If possible, I'd like to schedule a brief call at your convenience to address a few questions regarding your financials. When would you be available for a call in the next two weeks?

Thank you for your time and I look forward to your response.

[Investor Name]

[Investor Name]

[Investment Firm Name]

[Investment Firm Web Address]

Appendix C

Experimental Conditions and Email Addresses

Panel A: Black Female Conditions

<i>Black Female Retail</i>	<i>Black Female Professional</i>
<i>Aisha.Washington897@outlook.com</i>	<i>Aisha.Washington@bluewillowcapital.com</i>
<i>Aisha.Smalls284@gmail.com</i>	<i>Aisha.Smalls@fusionpointequities.com</i>
<i>Aisha.Pierre704@yahoo.com</i>	<i>Aisha.Pierre@globalviewsinvestments.com</i>
<i>Latoya.Washington130@yahoo.com</i>	<i>Latoya.Washington@globalviewsinvestments.com</i>
<i>Latoya.Smalls525@outlook.com</i>	<i>Latoya.Smalls@bluewillowcapital.com</i>
<i>Latoya.Pierre188@gmail.com</i>	<i>Latoya.Pierre@fusionpointequities.com</i>
<i>Tamika.Washington472@gmail.com</i>	<i>Tamika.Washington@fusionpointequities.com</i>
<i>Tamika.Smalls262@yahoo.com</i>	<i>Tamika.Smalls@globalviewsinvestments.com</i>
<i>Tamika.Pierre131@outlook.com</i>	<i>Tamika.Pierre@bluewillowcapital.com</i>

Panel B: Black Male Conditions

<i>Black Male Retail</i>	<i>Black Male Professional</i>
<i>Jamal.Washington987@gmail.com</i>	<i>Jamal.Washington@bluewillowcapital.com</i>
<i>Jamal.Smalls941@yahoo.com</i>	<i>Jamal.Smalls@fusionpointequities.com</i>
<i>Jamal.Pierre789@outlook.com</i>	<i>Jamal.Pierre@globalviewsinvestments.com</i>
<i>Kareem.Washington267@outlook.com</i>	<i>Kareem.Washington@globalviewsinvestments.com</i>
<i>Kareem.Smalls498@gmail.com</i>	<i>Kareem.Smalls@bluewillowcapital.com</i>
<i>Kareem.Pierre731@yahoo.com</i>	<i>Kareem.Pierre@fusionpointequities.com</i>
<i>Tyrone.Washington591@yahoo.com</i>	<i>Tyrone.Washington@fusionpointequities.com</i>
<i>Tyrone.Smalls129@outlook.com</i>	<i>Tyrone.Smalls@globalviewsinvestments.com</i>
<i>Tyrone.Pierre450@gmail.com</i>	<i>Tyrone.Pierre@bluewillowcapital.com</i>

Panel C: White Female Conditions

<i>White Female Retail</i>	<i>White Female Professional</i>
<i>Emily.Olson203@outlook.com</i>	<i>Emily.Olson@bluewillowcapital.com</i>
<i>Emily.Larson985@gmail.com</i>	<i>Emily.Larson@fusionpointequities.com</i>
<i>Emily.Schmidt677@yahoo.com</i>	<i>Emily.Schmidt@globalviewsinvestments.com</i>
<i>Jill.Olson519@yahoo.com</i>	<i>Jill.Olson@globalviewsinvestments.com</i>
<i>Jill.Larson706@outlook.com</i>	<i>Jill.Larson@bluewillowcapital.com</i>
<i>Jill.Schmidt493@gmail.com</i>	<i>Jill.Schmidt@fusionpointequities.com</i>
<i>Kristen.Olson544@gmail.com</i>	<i>Kristen.Olson@fusionpointequities.com</i>
<i>Kristen.Larson467@yahoo.com</i>	<i>Kristen.Larson@globalviewsinvestments.com</i>
<i>Kristen.Schmidt605@outlook.com</i>	<i>Kristen.Schmidt@bluewillowcapital.com</i>

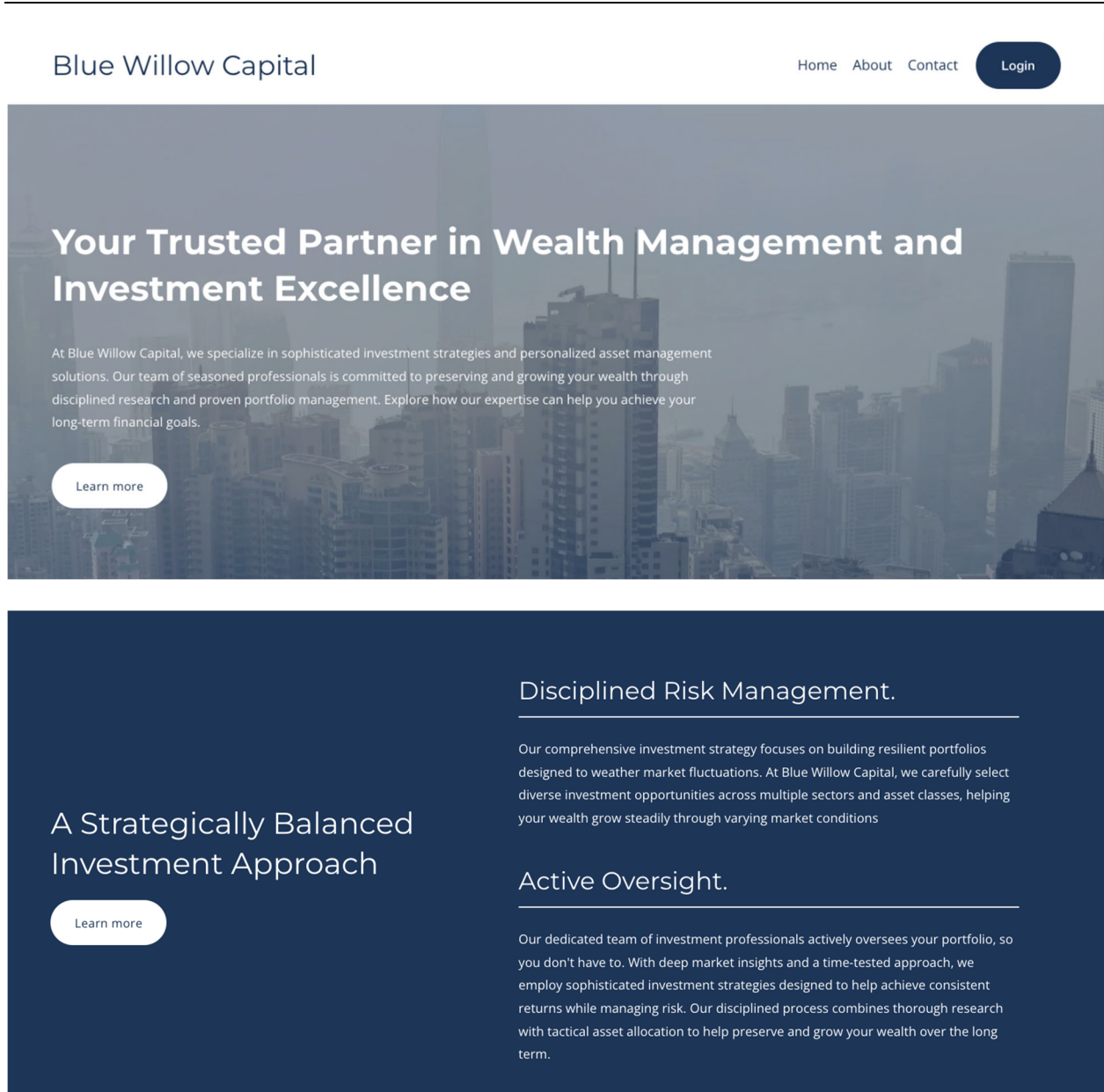
Panel D: White Male Conditions

<i>White Male Retail</i>	<i>White Male Professional</i>
<i>Brad.Olson766@outlook.com</i>	<i>Brad.Olson@bluewillowcapital.com</i>
<i>Brad.Larson650@gmail.com</i>	<i>Brad.Larson@fusionpointequities.com</i>
<i>Brad.Schmidt202@yahoo.com</i>	<i>Brad.Schmidt@globalviewsinvestments.com</i>
<i>Brendan.Olson537@yahoo.com</i>	<i>Brendan.Olson@globalviewsinvestments.com</i>
<i>Brendan.Larson170@outlook.com</i>	<i>Brendan.Larson@bluewillowcapital.com</i>
<i>Brendan.Schmidt146@gmail.com</i>	<i>Brendan.Schmidt@fusionpointequities.com</i>
<i>Matthew.Olson962@gmail.com</i>	<i>Matthew.Olson@fusionpointequities.com</i>
<i>Matthew.Larson506@yahoo.com</i>	<i>Matthew.Larson@globalviewsinvestments.com</i>
<i>Matthew.Schmidt758@outlook.com</i>	<i>Matthew.Schmidt@bluewillowcapital.com</i>

This appendix details the complete 2×2×2 experimental design with all email addresses used in each condition. Each condition contains 9 unique email addresses (3 first names × 3 last names), and each email was sent to approximately 38 firms for a total sample of 2,731 firms.

Exhibit 1

Professional Investor Website Example



This exhibit displays a representative example of the professionally designed websites created for our fictitious investment firms used in the professional investor experimental condition. Each of the three investment firms (Blue Willow Capital, Fusion Point Equities, and Global Views Investments) was supported by a custom website featuring typical elements of small investment firm websites, including company overviews, investment philosophy statements, and professional contact information. These websites were designed to enhance the credibility and realism of our professional investor manipulation, providing IR professionals with a verifiable online presence should they choose to research the contacting firm. The websites remained active throughout the experimental period and were designed to appear legitimate while avoiding any actual business operations or client solicitation.

Table 1
Sample Construction

<i>Sample Selection Criteria</i>	<i># of Firms</i>
Firms trading on the NYSE, AMEX, or NASDAQ as of most recent fiscal year-end	5,532
Exclude: Firms missing from WRDS SEC Analytics	(1,377)
Exclude: Firms not providing investor relations email information	(770)
Exclude: Firms with external investor relations representation	(654)
Firms included in randomization	2,731
Exclude: Firms with undeliverable email addresses	(80)
Firms included in analyses	2,651

This table describes our sample construction. We begin with all firms at the intersection of CRSP and Compustat with a CRSP share code of 10 or 11 and CRSP exchange code of 1, 2, or 3 as of the most recent fiscal period-end prior to launch. We require firms to be covered in the WRDS SEC Analytics database to retrieve earnings press releases and to have an investor relations email address in their earnings release. To minimize potential spillover effects, we exclude firms that have external investor relations representation. The preceding steps yield a sample of 2,731 firms, which we randomize to conditions as described in Section 3.1. While running the experiment, 80 email addresses were no longer in service or otherwise bounced, and we eliminated these firms prior to our primary analyses.

Table 2
Covariate Balance Across Conditions

Dependent Variable as:	(1) <i>Market Cap. Decile</i>	(2) <i>Personal IR Email</i>	(3) <i>Retail Ownership Decile</i>
<i>Experimentally Manipulated Variables:</i>			
Intercept	5.500*** (35.26)	0.452*** (16.73)	5.435*** (33.53)
Black Retail Female	0.000 (0.00)	0.003 (0.08)	0.048 (0.21)
Black Professional Female	0.000 (0.00)	0.003 (0.08)	0.058 (0.25)
Black Retail Male	0.000 (0.00)	-0.016 (-0.42)	0.122 (0.53)
Black Professional Male	-0.013 (-0.06)	-0.015 (-0.38)	-0.029 (-0.13)
White Retail Female	0.000 (0.00)	-0.018 (-0.46)	0.099 (0.43)
White Professional Female	0.000 (0.00)	-0.039 (-1.04)	0.118 (0.51)
White Retail Male	0.000 (0.00)	0.010 (0.27)	0.119 (0.52)
White Professional Male	Reference Group	Reference Group	Reference Group
N	2,719	2,731	2,524
Estimation Method	OLS	OLS	OLS

This table presents tests of covariate balance across our eight experimental conditions. The dependent variables are the stratification variables in our stratified randomization procedure: *Market Cap. Decile*, *Personal IR Email*, and *Retail Ownership Decile*. The independent variables of interest are each of the treatment arms created from our 2 x 2 x 2 experimental design. We include an intercept in the regression and omit the White professional male treatment indicator. The table reports coefficient estimates and t-statistics (in parentheses) based on robust standard errors from an ordinary least squares regression. ***, **, and * indicate statistical significance at the 1%, 5%, and 10% p-levels (two-tailed), respectively. Observations with missing covariate balance variables were also balanced across conditions but omitted from these regression analyses. Appendix A contains detailed variable definitions.

Table 3
Investor Characteristics and Investor Relations Meetings

Panel A: Summary Statistics				
	<i>Investor Professionalism</i>			
	Retail Investor		Professional Investor	
	<i>Gender</i>		<i>Gender</i>	
<i>Race</i>	Male	Female	Male	Female
White	18.1%	17.0%	19.8%	18.5%
	n=326	n=329	n=328	n=325
Black	14.5%	13.8%	12.4%	16.7%
	n=330	n=341	n=331	n=341

Panel B: Regression Results		
<i>Meeting as</i> Dependent Variable	(1)	(2)
<i>Experimentally Manipulated Variables:</i>		
Black	-0.292*** (-2.77)	-0.559** (-2.58)
Female	0.022 (0.21)	-0.088 (-0.44)
Retail	-0.073 (-0.70)	-0.112 (-0.56)
Black*Female		0.438 (1.47)
Black*Retail		0.298 (0.98)
Female*Retail		0.013 (0.05)
Black*Female*Retail		-0.426 (-1.01)
N	2,651	2,651
Estimation Method	Logistic	Logistic

This table presents data on the effect of investor race, gender, and professionalism on the likelihood of being offered a meeting with a corporate insider. The dependent variable is *Meeting*, an indicator variable equal to one if the firm offers to meet with the investor and zero otherwise. Panel A presents the mean and number of observations for each experimental condition. Panel B presents coefficient estimates and z-statistics (in parentheses) from logistic regressions. Our independent variables of interest are the main effects, two-way interactions, and three-way interaction of our manipulated investor characteristics: race, gender, and investor professionalism. ***, **, and * indicate statistical significance at the 1%, 5%, and 10% p-levels (two-tailed), respectively. Appendix A contains detailed variable definitions.

Table 4
Investor Characteristics and Investor Relations Responsiveness

Panel A: Summary Statistics

<i>Race</i>	<i>Investor Professionalism</i>			
	Retail Investor		Professional Investor	
	<i>Gender</i>		<i>Gender</i>	
	Male	Female	Male	Female
White	0.56 [1.16] n=326	0.59 [1.15] n=329	0.60 [1.20] n=328	0.57 [1.17] n=325
Black	0.50 [1.09] n=330	0.49 [1.06] n=341	0.40 [1.00] n=331	0.53 [1.13] n=341

Panel B: Regression Results

<i>Responsiveness as Dependent Variable</i>	(1)	(2)
<i>Experimentally Manipulated Variables:</i>		
Black	-0.190* (-1.93)	-0.429** (-2.04)
Female	0.116 (1.18)	-0.040 (-0.20)
Retail	0.068 (0.69)	-0.063 (-0.31)
Black*Female		0.389 (1.35)
Black*Retail		0.341 (1.17)
Female*Retail		0.196 (0.71)
Black*Female*Retail		-0.524 (-1.32)
N	2,651	2,651
Estimation Method	Ordered Logistic	Ordered Logistic

This table reports analyses on the effect of investor race, gender, and professionalism on investor relations responsiveness. The dependent variable is *Responsiveness*, an ordered variable taking values from 0 to 3, capturing the level of information provision, with higher values indicating more responsiveness. Panel A presents the mean, standard deviation [in brackets], and number of observations for each experimental condition. Panel B presents coefficient estimates and z-statistics (in parentheses) from ordered logistic regressions. Our independent variables of interest are the main effects, two-way interactions, and three-way interaction of our manipulated investor characteristics: race, gender, and investor professionalism. ***, **, and * indicate statistical significance at the 1%, 5%, and 10% p-levels (two-tailed), respectively. Appendix A contains detailed variable definitions.

Table 5
Investor Characteristics and Meeting with C-Suite Executive

Panel A: Percentage of Meetings Granted Involving a C-Suite Executive				
<i>Investor Professionalism</i>				
<i>Race</i>	Retail Investor		Professional Investor	
	<i>Gender</i>		<i>Gender</i>	
	Male	Female	Male	Female
White	8.5% n=59	1.8% n=56	6.2% n=65	5.0% n=60
Black	16.7% n=48	2.1% n=47	9.8% n=41	7.0% n=57

Panel B: Regression Results		
<i>C-Suite Meeting as Dependent Variable</i>	(1)	(2)
<i>Experimentally Manipulated Variables:</i>		
Black	0.582 (1.50)	0.500 (0.68)
Female	-0.978** (-2.39)	-0.220 (-0.28)
Retail	0.015 (0.04)	0.345 (0.49)
Black*Female		-0.140 (-0.13)
Black*Retail		0.270 (0.28)
Female*Retail		-1.408 (-1.03)
Black*Female*Retail		-0.452 (-0.24)
N	433	433
Estimation Method	Logistic	Logistic

This table reports analyses on the effect of investor race, gender, and professionalism on being offered a meeting with a C-suite executive. The dependent variable is *C-Suite Meeting*, an indicator variable equal to one if the firm offers to make a C-suite executive available to meet with the investor and zero otherwise. Panel A presents the percentage of meetings involving a C-suite executive in each experimental condition. Panel B presents coefficient estimates and z-statistics (in parentheses) from logistic regressions. Our independent variables of interest are the main effects, two-way interactions, and three-way interaction of our manipulated investor characteristics: race, gender, and investor professionalism. ***, **, and * indicate statistical significance at the 1%, 5%, and 10% p-levels (two-tailed), respectively. Appendix A contains detailed variable definitions.

Table 6
Investor Relations Professional Race and Gender Characteristics

	<u>Gender</u>		Total
	Female	Male	
<u>Race</u>			
Asian	53	126	179
Black	123	629	752
Hispanic Latino	38	244	282
White	436	999	1,435
Total	650	1,998	2,648

This table reports the estimated race and gender of the investor relations professionals named as the primary investor contact in our sample. The race and gender are estimated using the United States Namsor API, a machine learning algorithm used to estimate the race and gender of an individual based on first and last name. The tabulated estimates are using the algorithm's most likely race and most likely gender.

Table 7
Cross-Sectional Analyses of Investor Characteristics and Meeting Likelihood

Panel A: Firm Characteristics				
<i>Meeting as</i> Dependent Variable	(1) <i>Low Retail</i> <i>Investor</i> <i>Ownership %</i>	(2) <i>High Retail</i> <i>Investor</i> <i>Ownership %</i>	(3) <i>Small</i>	(4) <i>Large</i>
Black	-0.166 (-1.09)	-0.385** (-2.48)	-0.256* (-1.65)	-0.326** (-2.24)
Female	0.170 (1.11)	-0.060 (-0.39)	-0.232 (-1.50)	0.246* (1.69)
Retail	-0.044 (-0.29)	-0.080 (-0.52)	0.068 (0.44)	-0.197 (-1.36)
Difference in <i>Black</i>		-0.218		-0.070
Difference in <i>Female</i>		-0.230		0.478**
Difference in <i>Retail</i>		-0.037		-0.265
N	1,230	1,229	1,320	1,319
Estimation Method	Logistic	Logistic	Logistic	Logistic

Panel B: IR Professional Characteristics				
<i>Meeting as</i> Dependent Variable	(1) <i>Minority Race IR</i>	(2) <i>White IR</i>	(3) <i>Female IR</i>	(4) <i>Male IR</i>
Black	-0.320* (-1.94)	-0.285** (-2.07)	-0.227 (-1.11)	-0.321*** (-2.60)
Female	-0.024 (-0.15)	0.055 (0.40)	0.106 (0.51)	-0.005 (-0.04)
Retail	0.030 (0.18)	-0.122 (-0.89)	-0.174 (-0.84)	-0.043 (-0.35)
Difference in <i>Black</i>		0.035		-0.093
Difference in <i>Female</i>		0.079		-0.111
Difference in <i>Retail</i>		-0.153		0.132
N	1,216	1,435	650	1,998
Estimation Method	Logistic	Logistic	Logistic	Logistic

This table reports cross-sectional analyses on the effect of investor race, gender, and professionalism on the likelihood of being offered a meeting with a corporate insider. The dependent variable is *Meeting*, an indicator variable equal to one if the firm offers to meet with the investor and zero otherwise. Panel A displays results using firm characteristics as the cross-sectional variables. The cross-sectional analyses are split using the median of the cross-sectional variable. Panel B displays the results using the estimated race and gender of the investor relations contact for each firm. The sample included in the analysis is noted at the top of each column. The table reports coefficient estimates and z-statistics (in parentheses) from logistic regressions. Differences in coefficients across columns are tested using a Chi-squared test. ***, **, and * indicate statistical significance at the 1%, 5%, and 10% p-levels (two-tailed), respectively. Appendix A contains detailed variable definitions.

Table 8
Cross-Sectional Analyses of Investor Characteristics and IR Responsiveness

Panel A: Firm Characteristics				
<i>Responsiveness as Dependent Variable</i>	(1) <i>Low Retail Investor Ownership %</i>	(2) <i>High Retail Investor Ownership %</i>	(3) <i>Small</i>	(4) <i>Large</i>
Black	-0.087 (-0.61)	-0.301** (-2.07)	-0.111 (-0.77)	-0.263* (-1.94)
Female	0.288** (1.99)	-0.021 (-0.14)	-0.162 (-1.12)	0.364*** (2.65)
Retail	0.046 (0.32)	0.120 (0.82)	0.203 (1.40)	-0.054 (-0.40)
Difference in <i>Black</i>		-0.214		-0.152
Difference in <i>Female</i>		-0.308		0.526***
Difference in <i>Retail</i>		0.075		-0.257
N	1,230	1,229	1,320	1,319
Estimation Method	Ordered Logistic	Ordered Logistic	Ordered Logistic	Ordered Logistic

Panel B: IR Professional Characteristics				
<i>Responsiveness as Dependent Variable</i>	(1) <i>Minority Race IR</i>	(2) <i>White IR</i>	(3) <i>Female IR</i>	(4) <i>Male IR</i>
Black	-0.194 (-1.28)	-0.197 (-1.52)	-0.076 (-0.40)	-0.240** (-2.07)
Female	0.091 (0.60)	0.135 (1.03)	0.201 (1.05)	0.081 (0.70)
Retail	0.207 (1.35)	-0.011 (-0.08)	0.044 (0.23)	0.069 (0.60)
Difference in <i>Black</i>		-0.004		-0.165
Difference in <i>Female</i>		0.044		-0.119
Difference in <i>Retail</i>		0.216		0.027
N	1,216	1,435	650	1,998
Estimation Method	Ordered Logistic	Ordered Logistic	Ordered Logistic	Ordered Logistic

This table reports cross-sectional analyses on the effect of investor race, gender, and professionalism on IR responsiveness. The dependent variable is *Responsiveness*, which is a continuous variable capturing how responsive IR is. Panel A displays results using firm characteristics as the cross-sectional variables. The cross-sectional analyses are split using the median of the cross-sectional variable and the group included in the analysis is noted at the tops of the columns. Panel B displays the results using the estimated race and gender of the investor relations contact for each firm. The sample included in the analysis is noted at the top of each column. The table reports coefficient estimates and z-statistics (in parentheses) from ordered logistic regressions. ***, **, and * indicate statistical significance at the 1%, 5%, and 10% p-levels (two-tailed), respectively. Appendix A contains detailed variable definitions.

Table 9
Cross-Sectional Analyses of Investor Characteristics and Meeting with C-Suite Executive

Panel A: Firm Characteristics				
<i>C-suite Meeting as Dependent Variable</i>	(1) <i>Low Retail Investor Ownership %</i>	(2) <i>High Retail Investor Ownership %</i>	(3) <i>Small</i>	(4) <i>Large</i>
Black	0.579 (0.75)	0.812* (1.68)	0.574 (1.31)	0.679 (0.72)
Female	-2.030* (-1.96)	-0.657 (-1.31)	-0.718 (-1.53)	-1.593 (-1.32)
Retail	0.145 (0.19)	0.030 (0.06)	-0.148 (-0.34)	0.415 (0.43)
Difference in <i>Black</i>	0.233		0.105	
Difference in <i>Female</i>	1.373		-0.875	
Difference in <i>Retail</i>	-0.116		0.563	
N	209	203	199	234
Estimation Method	Logistic	Logistic	Logistic	Logistic

Panel B: IR Professional Characteristics				
<i>C-Suite Meeting as Dependent Variable</i>	(1) <i>Minority Race IR</i>	(2) <i>White IR</i>	(3) <i>Female IR</i>	(4) <i>Male IR</i>
Black	0.958 (1.63)	0.279 (0.54)	0.018 (0.48)	0.047 (1.47)
Female	-0.986 (-1.57)	-0.938* (-1.67)	-0.077** (-2.01)	-0.050* (-1.65)
Retail	0.185 (0.32)	-0.146 (-0.28)	-0.029 (-0.87)	0.012 (0.39)
Difference in <i>Black</i>	-0.679		0.029	
Difference in <i>Female</i>	0.048		0.028	
Difference in <i>Retail</i>	-0.331		0.041	
N	174	259	115	318
Estimation Method	Logistic	Logistic	OLS	OLS

This table reports cross-sectional analyses on the effect of investor race, gender, and professionalism on being offered a meeting with a C-suite executive. The dependent variable is *C-Suite Meeting*, an indicator variable equal to one if the firm offers to make a C-suite executive available to meet with the investor and zero otherwise. Panel A displays results using firm characteristics as the cross-sectional variables. The cross-sectional analyses are split using the median of the cross-sectional variable and the group included in the analysis is noted at the tops of the columns. Panel B displays the results using the estimated race and gender of the investor relations contact for each firm. The sample included in the analysis is noted at the top of each column. The table reports coefficient estimates and z-statistics (in parentheses) from logistic regressions, except for Panel B Columns 3 and 4, which report coefficient estimates and t-statistics (in parentheses) from OLS regressions. ***, **, and * indicate statistical significance at the 1%, 5%, and 10% p-levels (two-tailed), respectively. Appendix A contains detailed variable definitions.

Data Simulation and Power Analyses

We conduct simulation-based power analyses to ensure that our study is sufficiently powered to detect meaningful effects at conventional significance levels for our primary tests. This approach prevents us from proposing an underpowered field experiment (Floyd and List [2016], List [2011]), thereby enhancing the interpretability of our results.

The assumptions we make in our power analysis are primarily based on results from Heinrichs [2014], a field experiment involving email correspondence with corporate IR departments by either a fictional hedge fund manager or a consultant. Within the hedge fund condition, Heinrichs [2014] documents a 44% email response rate, with 73% of responses resulting in a meeting. Thus, we use 32% as the base probability for a White male professional investor in our setting. To our knowledge, this is the only study closely related to ours, providing a relevant basis for our assumptions. In our setting, we sampled all publicly traded firms with internal IR departments, totaling approximately 2,750 firms with identifiable email contact information. We estimated the minimum detectable effect (MDE) at various power levels, focusing on achieving 80% power, which is considered the standard for adequate power (Cohen [1992], Land and Zheng [2010]).

Methodology

We conduct two separate power analyses: one for our primary binary dependent variable (Meeting) and the second for our continuous dependent variables (*Responsiveness*, *Speed of Meeting*, *Speed of Response*, and *Seniority*). For each analysis, we follow this procedure:

1. Simulate the dependent variable for a model with only main effects. We run a logistic regression on simulated data for the binary dependent variable and OLS regression for continuous variables.

2. Extract the p-value.
3. Repeat steps 1-2 1,000 times, with the proportion of simulations where $p < .05$ representing our power.
4. Repeat steps 1-3 for a range of main effect sizes to determine the MDE (i.e., the smallest effect size with power $\geq .8$).
5. Repeat steps 1-4 for two-way interaction models, keeping the main effect constant at the MDE found in previous simulations.
6. Repeat steps 1-5 for three-way interaction models, keeping the main effect and two-way effects constant at the MDE found in previous simulations.

Power Analysis Results

Binary Dependent Variable (Meeting)

The power analyses for the main-effects model, the two-way interaction models, and the three-way interaction models at varying power levels and effect sizes (in units of log-odds) for *Meeting* are displayed in IA Figure 1, Panel A. For each model at 80% power, the MDE is as follows:

- Main-effects-only model: -0.26 log-odds, equivalent to an odds ratio of 0.77.
- Two-way interactions model: -0.60 log-odds, equivalent to an odds ratio of 0.55.
- Three-way interaction model: Insufficient power.

According to Cohen's rule of thumb, an effect size (in units of Cohen's d) of 0.2 is "small," 0.5 is "medium," and 0.8 is "large" (Cohen [1992]). Odds ratios of approximately 0.68 (small effect), 0.4 (medium effect), and 0.25 (large effect) correspond to these Cohen's d effect sizes (Chen et al. [2010]). Therefore, we have the power to detect small effects for main effects and

small-to-medium effects for two-way interactions.²¹ Since we do have sufficient power for the three-way interaction for our continuous variables (see the next section), we will tabulate the three-way interaction results for our binary dependent variables for completeness.

Continuous Dependent Variables (Responsiveness, Speed of Meeting, Speed of Response, and Seniority)

For these variables, we standardize the data using the mean and standard deviation of the baseline group (White, male, professional investors). Given the lack of prior findings in this setting, this standardization is necessary as we cannot estimate the distribution of these variables *ex ante*. The standardization also has the effect of transforming our units of analysis to Cohen's *d* (i.e., the mean difference between treatment groups scaled by the standard deviation), resulting in our continuous variables having the same MDE in units of Cohen's *d*. The power analyses for the main-effects model, the two-way interaction models, and the three-way interaction models at varying power levels and effect sizes (in units of Cohen's *d*) are displayed in IA Figure 1, Panel B. For each model at 80% power, the MDE is as follows:

- Main-effects-only model: 0.11 Cohen's *d*
- Two-way interactions model: 0.21 Cohen's *d*
- Three-way interaction model: 0.45 Cohen's *d*

Therefore, we have the power to detect small effects for main effects and two-way interactions and small-to-medium effects for three-way interactions.

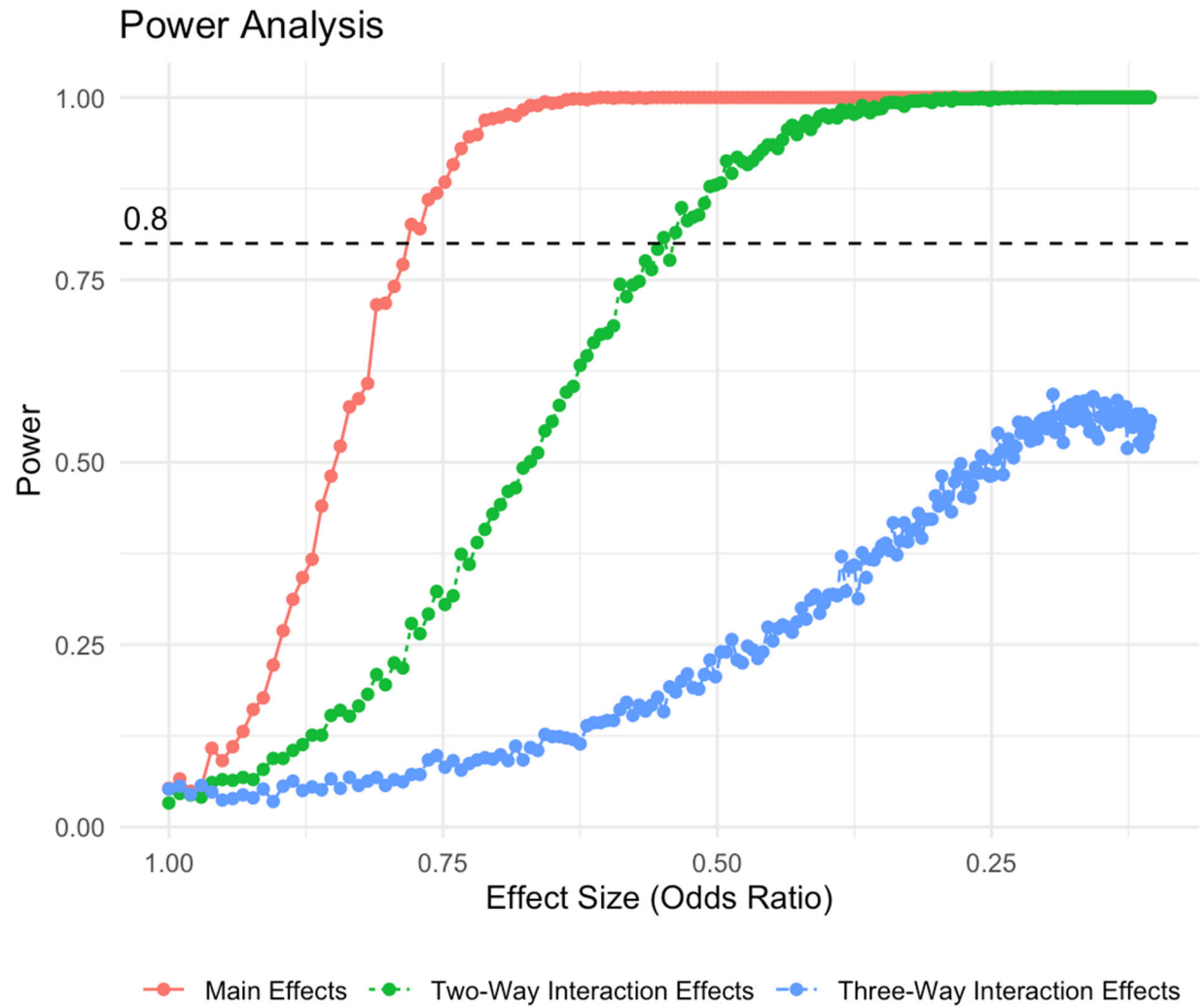
Overall, our simulation-based power analyses provide robust evidence that our study is adequately powered to detect meaningful effects at conventional significance levels for both our primary binary dependent variable (*Meeting*) and our secondary continuous dependent variables

²¹ Note that our two-way interaction power analyses in this section are applicable to our cross-sectional tests.

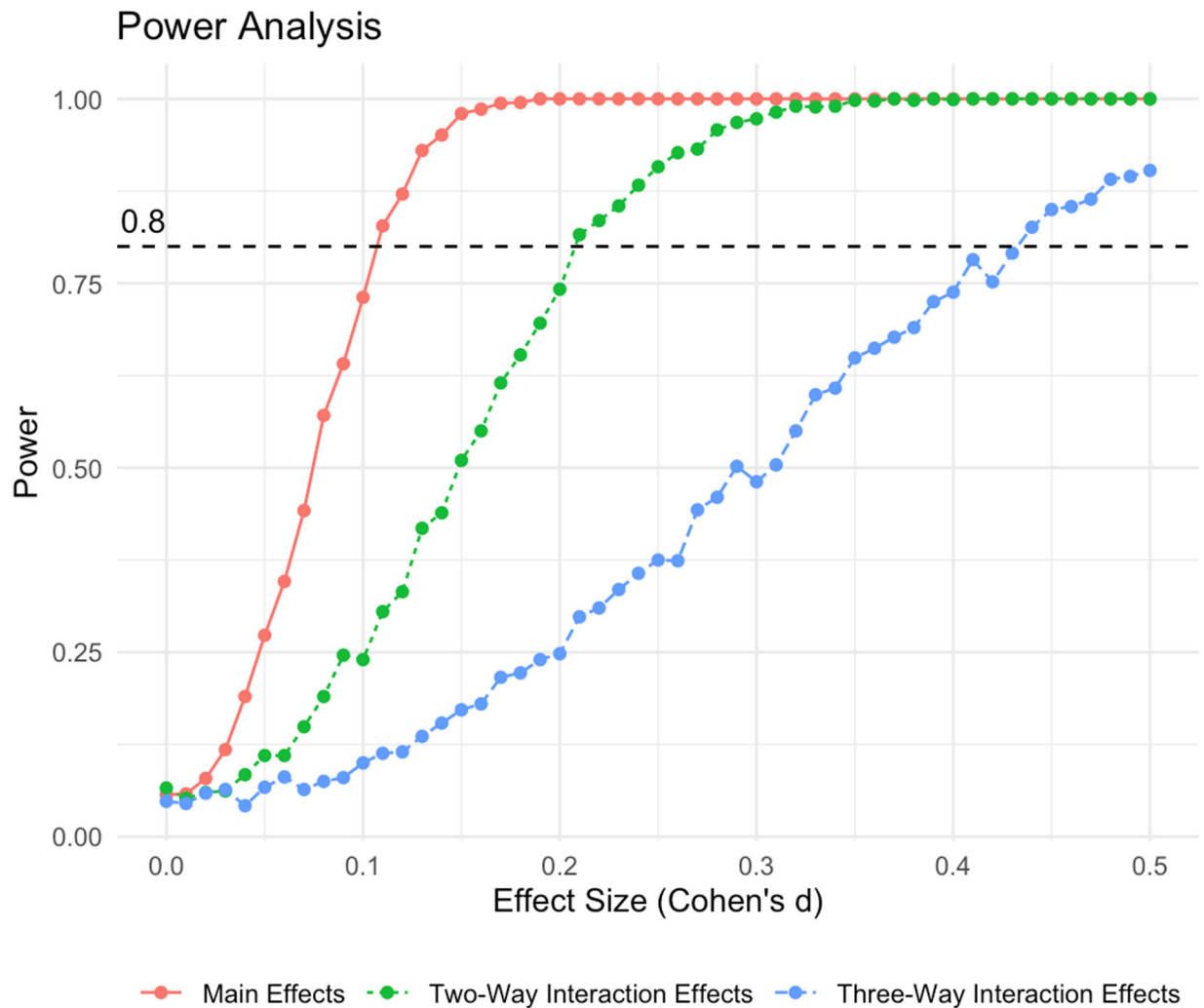
(Responsiveness, Speed of Meeting, Speed of Response, and Seniority). Further, due to the number of additional assumptions and complexity required, our power analyses do not account for the stratified randomization procedure to assign companies, which should only further reduce variation not caused by the treatment condition. Thus, our MDEs are conservative estimates in this regard. By ensuring that our study is well-powered, we can be assured that the insights gleaned will be both meaningful and relevant, irrespective of the ultimate findings.

IA Figure 1 Data-Simulated Power Analyses

Panel A: Power Analysis for *Meeting*



Panel B: Power Analysis for *Responsiveness*, *Speed of Response*, *Speed of Meeting*, and *Seniority*



The figure displays the results of our data-simulated power analysis. Panel A graphs the power analyses for the main-effects model, two-way interaction models, and three-way interaction models at varying effect sizes (in units of odds ratio) for *Meeting* (binary dependent variable). The results reveal that we have the power to detect small effects for main effects and small-to-medium effects for two-way interactions. Panel B graphs the power analyses for the main-effects model, two-way interaction models, and three-way interaction models at varying effect sizes (in units of Cohen's d) for *Responsiveness*, *Speed of Response*, *Speed of Meeting*, and *Seniority*. The results reveal that we have the power to detect small effects for main effects and two-way interactions and small-to-medium effects for three-way interactions.

IA Table 1
Covariate Balance Across Conditions

Panel A: Race Manipulation

<i>Variable</i>	<u>Mean</u>			<u>Std. Dev.</u>		
	<i>White</i>	<i>Black</i>	<i>Difference</i>	<i>White</i>	<i>Black</i>	<i>Difference</i>
Market Capitalization	10,559	9,874	685	30,260	28,076	2,184
Personal Email	44%	45%	-1%	50%	50%	0%
Retail Ownership	35%	34%	1%	33%	33%	0%

Panel B: Gender Manipulation

<i>Variable</i>	<u>Mean</u>			<u>Std. Dev.</u>		
	<i>Male</i>	<i>Female</i>	<i>Difference</i>	<i>Male</i>	<i>Female</i>	<i>Difference</i>
Market Capitalization	10,040	10,394	-354	28,512	29,852	-1,340
Personal Email	45%	44%	1%	50%	50%	0%
Retail Ownership	35%	35%	0%	33%	33%	0%

Panel C: Professionalism Manipulation

<i>Variable</i>	<u>Mean</u>			<u>Std. Dev.</u>		
	<i>Professional</i>	<i>Retail</i>	<i>Difference</i>	<i>Professional</i>	<i>Retail</i>	<i>Difference</i>
Market Capitalization	10,138	10,296	-158	29,186	29,196	-10
Personal Email	44%	45%	-1%	50%	50%	0%
Retail Ownership	34%	35%	-1%	33%	33%	0%

This table presents the means and standard deviations of characteristics we use in our stratified randomization procedures. Panel A presents these statistics across our race manipulation, Panel B across our gender manipulation, and Panel C across our professionalism manipulation. The ‘Difference’ column presents the difference in means (standard deviation) using a t-test (F-test). ***, **, and * indicate statistical significance at the 1%, 5%, and 10% p-levels (two-tailed), respectively. Appendix A contains detailed variable definitions.

IA Table 2
Investor Characteristics and Investor Relations Responsiveness (OLS)

<i>Responsiveness as</i> Dependent Variable	(1)	(2)
<i>Experimentally Manipulated Variables:</i>		
Black	-0.101** (-2.32)	-0.205** (-2.38)
Female	0.031 (0.71)	-0.031 (-0.34)
Retail	0.012 (0.28)	-0.036 (-0.39)
Black*Female		0.169 (1.37)
Black*Retail		0.143 (1.17)
Female*Retail		0.060 (0.46)
Black*Female*Retail		-0.211 (-1.21)
N	2,651	2,651
Estimation Method	OLS	OLS

This table reports analyses on the effect of investor race, gender, and professionalism on investor relations responsiveness. The dependent variable is *Responsiveness*, an ordered variable taking values from 0 to 3, capturing the level of information provision, with higher values indicating more responsiveness. The table presents coefficient estimates and t-statistics (in parentheses) from OLS regressions. Our independent variables of interest are the main effects, two-way interactions, and three-way interaction of our manipulated investor characteristics: race, gender, and investor professionalism. ***, **, and * indicate statistical significance at the 1%, 5%, and 10% p-levels (two-tailed), respectively. Appendix A contains detailed variable definitions.

IA Table 3
Investor Characteristics and Investor Relations Response Time

Panel A: Summary Statistics

	<i>Investor Professionalism</i>			
	Retail Investor		Professional Investor	
	<i>Gender</i>		<i>Gender</i>	
<i>Race</i>	Male	Female	Male	Female
White	48.1	32.1	22.8	31.8
	n=51	n=55	n=61	n=60
Black	24.7	14.9	27.9	21.1
	n=43	n=47	n=40	n=57

Panel B: Regression Results

<i>Speed of Response as</i> Dependent Variable	(1)	(2)
<i>Experimentally Manipulated Variables:</i>		
Black	-9.904*	0.655
	(-1.94)	(0.22)
Female	-7.992	-0.182
	(-1.40)	(-0.06)
Retail	4.709	-0.036
	(0.90)	(-0.01)
N	481	481
Estimation Method	OLS	Quantile

This table presents data on the effect of investor race, gender, and professionalism on the speed of initial investor relations response. The dependent variable is *Speed of Response*, a continuous variable equal to the number of hours until the first non-automated response from the firm. Panel A presents the mean and number of observations for each experimental condition. Panel B presents coefficient estimates and t-statistics (in parentheses) from ordinary least squares (Column 1) and quantile (Column 2) regressions. ***, **, and * indicate statistical significance at the 1%, 5%, and 10% p-levels (two-tailed), respectively. Appendix A contains detailed variable definitions.